

What's in a Name? Perceived Ethnic Discrimination in Tokyo's Rental Housing Market*

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Abstract

This paper studies perceived ethnic discrimination as a market-access friction in Tokyo's rental housing market. We first show that Japan's private rental market offers limited statutory protection against nationality-based exclusion, leaving discriminatory screening weakly constrained. We then use a name-based survey experiment in which native Japanese and foreign-born residents evaluate whether otherwise identical applicants would receive a viewing invitation. Both groups expect non-Japanese applicants to face lower access probabilities than Japanese applicants. Foreign-born respondents' evaluations capture group-level auto-stereotypes of minority disadvantage; native Japanese respondents' evaluations capture hetero-stereotypes. Native Japanese respondents perceive larger penalties, indicating a Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy. Among foreign-born respondents, prior everyday discrimination predicts more pessimistic access expectations, yet respondents rate their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group, consistent with the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy. Platform evidence showing visible nationality-related screening links these perceptions to an institutional setting in which exclusion remains publicly observable.

Keywords: Perceived discrimination; Rental housing; Ethnic discrimination; Anti-discrimination law; Japan

JEL codes: J15, R31, R21, C90, D91, K38

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1 Introduction

Access to housing is central to social and economic integration, yet discrimination in rental markets remains widespread, particularly for ethnic minorities and immigrants. Housing discrimination matters not only because it restricts access to accommodation, but also because it may shape neighbourhood choice, labour-market integration, and broader patterns of social inclusion. Focusing on the rental market is especially salient in the Tokyo context, where renting constitutes the dominant tenure form: the homeownership rate is approximately 44.6% in Tokyo, compared to around 61% nationwide, implying that a majority of households in the capital rely on rental housing.¹ Japan provides a particularly important setting in which to study these dynamics. Following the 2018 immigration reform, the country has experienced growing reliance on foreign labour and a rising foreign-born population (Chiavacci, 2025), while comprehensive anti-discrimination protections in the private rental market remain limited.

In this paper, we study perceived discrimination as a market-access friction. Rental search is shaped not only by prices, locations, and dwelling characteristics, but also by applicants' beliefs about the probability that landlords or real-estate agents will respond to them. When prospective tenants expect lower access probabilities, anticipated discrimination may alter search intensity, application strategies, neighbourhood choice, and willingness to participate in particular segments of the housing market. Beliefs about discrimination may therefore affect market outcomes even before any realised act of discrimination is observed. These beliefs also have a broader social-status dimension, because expectations about who is likely to obtain housing reflect beliefs about belonging and group standing. Our main object of interest is therefore the perceived probability of access to the rental market.

Existing evidence suggests that exclusionary behaviour in Japan's housing market remains persistent. Correspondence studies document differential treatment by landlords and real-estate agents (Sugasawa and Harano, 2023), while repeated nationwide surveys commissioned by the Japanese Ministry of Justice report that foreign residents frequently experience difficulties securing housing. Exclusionary screening practices also remain visible in publicly accessible rental advertisements, where expressions such as 'no foreigners,' 'foreigners negotiable,' and 'foreigners allowed' continue to appear on major housing platforms.² This evidence aligns with a broader audit- and field-experimental literature measuring discrimination in housing and related markets, including studies on trends in discrimination and racial disparities in urban housing outcomes (Ross, 2017; Gould Ellen and Ross, 2018). Such studies identify whether differential treatment occurs. They do not, however, reveal how market participants perceive the probability of access faced by different groups. This distinction matters because perceived access constraints can shape economic behaviour independently of realised landlord responses.

Perceived access probabilities matter for two reasons. First, subjective expectations are economically consequential: anticipated rejection may influence search intensity, application strategies, neighbourhood choice, and residential sorting. Perceived barriers to housing access may therefore contribute to unequal integration outcomes even when realised discriminatory behaviour is

¹See <https://stats-japan.com/t/kiji/11963>, last accessed in May 2026.

²See Ministry of Justice Japan, 2024 Report on the Basic Survey Foreign Residents, available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001436052.pdf> (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001450859.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001436044.pdf>); 2022 Report on the Basic Survey of Foreign Residents, available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001402047.pdf> (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415876.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415884.pdf>); 2021 Report on the Basic Survey of Foreign Residents, available at <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001378514.pdf> (English summary available at: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415911.pdf> as well as the questionnaire used: <https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001415921.pdf>).

not directly observed. Relatedly, Boeri et al. (2015) show that housing-market discrimination may affect immigrant integration beyond housing itself by shaping residential concentration and employment outcomes. Second, perceived access also has a social-status dimension, because beliefs about who is likely to obtain housing reflect broader beliefs about belonging and group standing. Experimental evidence further suggests that discriminatory behaviour is sensitive not only to private preferences but also to perceived social norms regarding the acceptability of discrimination (Barr et al., 2018), and recent work shows that laws may influence social norms and normative beliefs beyond direct legal enforcement (Lane et al., 2023).

We therefore adopt a complementary survey-experimental approach inspired by Lepinteur et al. (2025). Rather than observing realised outcomes directly, we elicit expectations about housing access from native Japanese and foreign-born residents in Tokyo. Respondents evaluate the likelihood that otherwise identical rental applicants receive a viewing invitation for the same property. Applicant characteristics are held constant except for ethnically identifiable names, allowing us to isolate perceived name-based differences in access across Japanese, Indonesian, Chinese, Western, Western-Japanese, Vietnamese, and South Korean profiles. The design allows us to measure perceived access probabilities for different applicant groups and to compare these beliefs across respondent groups.

The paper studies two distinct belief gaps in perceived access probabilities. The first compares foreign-born respondents’ beliefs about their own access probability with their beliefs about the access probability of applicants from their broader nationality group. This corresponds to the *Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy* (PGDD), a well-established concept in social psychology (Crosby, 1982; Taylor et al., 1990, 1996; Dion, 2001). Housing-related evidence on PGDD remains scarce and has focused mainly on Canada (Dion, 2001) and, more recently, Europe (Martiniello, 2025). The second belief gap compares majority and minority respondents’ beliefs about the access probability of the same non-Japanese applicants. We refer to this as *Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy* (GGDD). Whereas PGDD operates between personal and group-level beliefs, GGDD operates between majority and minority assessments of the same group-level access constraint.

The Tokyo setting is useful for studying these belief gaps. Japan’s immigration and social institutions continue to reflect persistent ethnic hierarchies (Shipper, 2016). Scholarship on East Asian migration regimes further suggests that foreign workers are often incorporated as economically necessary yet socially temporary populations (Bell and Piper, 2005; Stilz, 2010). At the same time, Japan lacks comprehensive statutory anti-discrimination protections in private rental housing, and enforcement against nationality-based exclusion remains comparatively limited. In such an institutional environment, beliefs about access probabilities may be especially important because applicants’ expectations are formed in a market where exclusionary practices remain visible and where legal constraints on screening are relatively weak.

Our focus on perceived discrimination connects to a broader public-economics literature showing that subjective beliefs and biased perceptions can shape economically consequential preferences and decisions. For example, Cruces et al. (2013) use a survey experiment to show that biased perceptions of the income distribution affect redistributive preferences. In a similar spirit, our experiment studies beliefs about unequal access in the rental market: rather than measuring landlord behaviour directly, we examine how Japanese and foreign-born respondents perceive the likelihood that otherwise identical applicants receive access to housing. The use of naturally occurring identity categories and third-party evaluations also helps address external-validity concerns raised in experimental studies relying on artificial group assignments or direct measures of discriminatory behaviour (Lane, 2016).

We document six main findings. First, both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents

expect non-Japanese applicants to face substantially lower viewing probabilities than otherwise identical Japanese applicants. Second, native Japanese respondents perceive significantly larger penalties than foreign-born respondents. We interpret this pattern as evidence of GGDD: majority and minority respondents recognise disadvantage facing non-Japanese applicants, but foreign-born respondents perceive this disadvantage less strongly than native Japanese respondents. Third, perceived disadvantage varies systematically across applicant groups and is smallest for Western-Japanese applicants, suggesting that perceived access is shaped not only by foreignness itself but also by signals of cultural proximity and partial insider status. Fourth, among foreign-born respondents, prior experiences of everyday discrimination are associated with more pessimistic expectations regarding rental access, while Japanese-language proficiency is positively associated with perceived access. Fifth, foreign-born respondents evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group, consistent with PGDD. A benchmark using native Japanese respondents shows no comparable self-evaluation premium relative to the Japanese applicant, suggesting that the personal-group gap is not simply driven by general self-optimism but is concentrated among foreign-born respondents. Sixth, exploratory mechanism evidence suggests that differences in perceived access may partly reflect informational asymmetries: foreign-born respondents with very limited Japanese-language proficiency perceive substantially smaller Japanese-applicant advantages, consistent with the idea that access to Japanese-language housing-market signals shapes perceptions of discrimination.

This paper contributes to the literature in three ways. First, it shifts attention from realised discrimination to beliefs about market access. While correspondence studies identify realised differential treatment, our approach captures perceived access probabilities, which may themselves shape search behaviour, application strategies, and residential sorting. Second, the paper provides new evidence on perceived discrimination in a non-Western housing market where rental housing is economically central and anti-discrimination enforcement remains limited. Third, the paper contributes to the literature on discrimination perceptions by showing that beliefs about housing-market access differ both between personal and group-level assessments and between majority and minority evaluations of the same minority-group disadvantage. These belief gaps are economically relevant because they describe how different groups perceive the constraints governing access to a high-stakes market.

The remainder of the paper is organised as follows: section 2 discusses the historical, institutional, and legal background of Tokyo’s rental housing market. Thereafter, section 3 describes the survey design and experimental methodology. Next, section 4 presents the empirical analyses, and section 5 discusses implications. Finally, section 6 concludes. The Appendix reports supplementary materials.

2 Historical, Legal, and Institutional Context

2.1 Restrictive Immigration Policy and Ethnic Hierarchies in Japan

2.1.1 Labour Import Without ‘Immigration’

For decades, Japan denied the need for an immigration policy, instead implementing a system of de facto labour importation through side and back door entry while limiting pathways to long-term settlement and integration for foreign nationals (Vermillo Herman, 2021). In official discourse, the Japanese government has continued to reject the notion of ‘immigration,’ treating immigration as implying permanent settlement and integration (Hasegawa, 2023). Similar dynamics have been observed more broadly across East Asian migration regimes, where foreign workers are frequently incorporated as economically necessary labour while remaining socially

and politically temporary populations (Bell and Piper, 2005). In such systems, migrants are often treated as labour market participants rather than prospective long-term members of the national community.

This distinction between labour admission and immigration resembles the broader logic of guestworker regimes, which admit foreign workers as a temporary and functionally necessary labour force while restricting claims to settlement, family life, and political membership (Surak, 2013). While the 2018 reform introduced two new visa categories — Specified Skilled Worker (SSW) Type 1 and 2 — explicitly recognising the need for lower-qualified labour (Chiavacci, 2025), former Prime Minister Shinzo Abe nevertheless stated during a Diet session on 29 October 2018³ that ‘the government has no intention to adopt a so-called immigration policy.’ Despite this official framing, the reform marked a substantial shift in Japan’s migration regime. Chiavacci (2025) even characterises the reform as “a dam break in Japan’s immigration policy,” reflecting the disruptive nature of the institutional transition toward greater reliance on foreign labour. This transition increases the importance of understanding how foreign-born residents are perceived within key markets such as housing, where access depends heavily on private screening decisions.

2.1.2 Ethnic Hierarchies and Differential Integration

The 2018 reforms were primarily driven by demographic pressures, labour shortages, and co-ordinated business lobbying rather than a broader shift toward multicultural integration (Vermillo Herman, 2021). Despite institutional reforms, immigration policy in Japan continues to reflect ethnonationalist frameworks and differentiated perceptions of cultural compatibility (Shipper, 2016). Existing research suggests that immigrants are incorporated into a relatively clear ethnic hierarchy, in which co-ethnic and culturally proximate groups are often treated more favourably than other migrant populations (Tsuda, 1998). In the Japanese context, anti-immigrant attitudes are further found to be strongly shaped by concerns regarding identity and cultural homogeneity (Davison and Peng, 2021).

Figure 1 illustrates the increase in Tokyo’s foreign resident population following the 2018 immigration reform, despite a temporary slowdown during the COVID-19 period.

Corresponding figures for individual nationality groups are shown in Figure 7 in the Appendix.

2.2 Tenant-Protective Property Law and the Spatial Structure of Tokyo

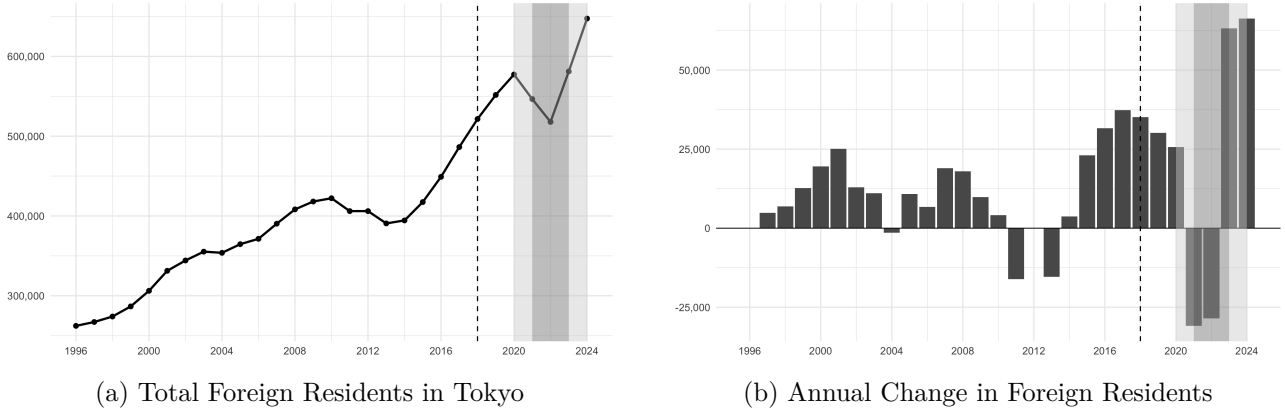
Tokyo’s contemporary rental housing market is shaped by a historically entrenched system of strong tenant protections and long-term reliance on rental housing. Unlike housing systems in which renting primarily serves as a temporary stage before homeownership, renting constitutes a central and often long-term tenure form in Tokyo. This makes access to rental housing particularly important for social and economic integration, especially for foreign-born residents.

The institutional structure of Tokyo’s rental market reflects a longer historical development involving the evolution of tenant protections, the historical organisation of urban landholding, and postwar patterns of rental dependence. In particular, Japan’s strong tenant-protection regime, including automatic lease renewal and the “just cause” requirement, has historically encouraged relatively stable and long-term tenancy relations while also contributing to risk-averse screening behaviour among landlords. Additional historical background on the development of Tokyo’s rental housing market is provided in Appendix A.

Despite the introduction of fixed-term leases in 2000, much of Tokyo’s rental market remains

³<https://mainichi.jp/english/articles/20181029/p2a/00m/0na/032000c>, last accessed in May 2026.

Figure 1: Foreign Residents in Tokyo, 1996–2024



Notes: The dashed vertical line marks the *2018 Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act* reform. Shaded areas indicate the COVID-19 period. The darker shaded region corresponds to years fully affected by pandemic-related restrictions, while lighter shaded regions correspond to partially affected years. Data are from the *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook*.

structurally oriented toward relatively stable occupancy rather than short-term tenant turnover. Combined with comparatively low homeownership rates in Tokyo, this institutional structure increases the importance of equitable access to rental housing.

Existing research documents persistent socio-economic and spatial inequalities within Tokyo’s housing market. Although segregation levels are generally lower than in many Western metropolitan areas, disparities remain visible across occupational, income, and ethnic dimensions (Masaya, 2021; Fielding, 2004; Fujita and Hill, 2012). Foreign-born residents are concentrated in specific wards such as Shinjuku and Edogawa, reflecting both labour-market sorting and historical migration networks.⁴

Tokyo’s rental market therefore provides an important setting in which to study perceived discrimination. Access to rental housing is frequently mediated through private landlords and real-estate agents, creating substantial scope for unequal treatment at the screening stage. Existing studies further suggest that social perceptions and cultural proximity continue to shape attitudes toward foreign-born residents in Japan (Davison and Peng, 2021; Shipper, 2016).

2.3 Weak Anti-discrimination Law

2.3.1 Absence of Comprehensive Housing Anti-discrimination Law

Article 14 of the Japanese Constitution prohibits discrimination on several grounds, including race, creed, sex, social status, and family origin. Japan also became a party to the International Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Racial Discrimination (ICERD) in 1995, which entered into force domestically in 1996. In the housing context, Japanese courts have recognised certain forms of nationality-based differential treatment as unlawful under tort law and the principle of good faith in the Japanese Civil Code, particularly where landlords

⁴Immigration Services Agency (2024) data indicate that Shinjuku has the largest foreign-born resident population among Tokyo’s 23 wards.

or real-estate agents refused to conclude tenancy agreements with non-Japanese applicants.⁵ More recently, the Tokyo District Court awarded damages against a real-estate agency that expressed unwillingness to rent to persons from a particular country.⁶

However, unlike the United Kingdom and European Union member states, Japan does not have statutory anti-discrimination provisions explicitly regulating differential treatment in the housing sector, nor an independent national human rights or equality body with monitoring/enforcement powers. In the United Kingdom, the *Equality Act 2010* expressly prohibits race discrimination in relation to the disposal and management of premises in the housing sector.⁷ At the European Union level, the *Racial Equality Directive* (2000/43/EC) requires Member States to prohibit discrimination in access to and supply of goods and services available to the public, including housing, both in the public and private sector. The Directive further requires Member States to designate bodies for promotion of equal treatment and establish effective, proportionate, and dissuasive sanctions for infringements of anti-discrimination law.⁸ All Member States have now transposed this Directive to their national laws (?).

A lack of statutory anti-discrimination provisions appears to be reflected in the continued public visibility of nationality-based screening language within the Japanese housing sector, as discussed in the following section. This contrasts with the position in jurisdictions such as the United Kingdom, the European Union, and the United States.⁹ Taking the United Kingdom as an example, race, including nationality, is a protected characteristic under anti-discrimination law,¹⁰ and the Equality and Human Rights Commission's Code of Practice treats advertisements expressing preferences or restrictions based on race or nationality amount to direct discrimination.¹¹ Accordingly, such advertisements are themselves unlawful, irrespective of whether any individual applicant can demonstrate discriminatory treatment in a particular transaction. Unlike indirect discrimination, which may be justified as a proportionate means of achieving a legitimate aim, direct race discrimination generally admits of no comparative justification defence.¹² Under UK equality law, deliberately segregating service users on racial grounds is treated as less favourable treatment.¹³ From this perspective, the existence of housing providers or property listings specifically marketed as suitable for foreign national would not necessarily resolve concerns about discrimination if their practical effect is to channel foreign applicants into separate segments of the housing market rather than ensuring equal access the market as a whole.

The United Nations' *Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination* repeatedly ex-

⁵Osaka High Court, 5 October 2006; Osaka High Court, 22 March 2007; Kyoto District Court, 2 October 2007.

⁶Tokyo District Court, 9 October 2019.

⁷Equality Act 2010, ss4, 9(1)(b), 13, 19, 26, 27 and 33-35.

⁸Art 3(1)(h), 13, 15.

⁹In the United States, the Fair Housing Act 42 USC §3604(c) explicitly prohibits discriminatory housing advertisements based on race or national origin.

¹⁰Equality Act 2010 s9; as to nationality, see s9(1)(b); *Mandla v Dowell Lee* [1983] AC 548; *Ealing LBC v CRE* [1972] AC 342.

¹¹Equality Act 2010 s13; Equality and Human Rights Commission, 'Guidance: Services, Public Functions and Associations: Code of Practice' (published 1 January 2011) 4.31 states 'If a service provider advertises that in offering a service they will treat applicants less favourably because of a protected characteristic, this would amount to direct discrimination'. Accessible at <https://www.equalityhumanrights.com/equality/equality-act-2010/codes-practice/services-public-functions-and-associations-code-0> In any case, under Equality Act 2006 s24A, the Commission has power to apply to the court for an injunction to deal with the publication of an advertisement suggesting that a service provider would discriminate (see the Code 14.61).

¹²cf. Equality Act 2010 s19(2)(d).

¹³Equality Act 2010 s 13(5).

pressed concerns regarding discriminatory treatment by private actors in Japan, particularly discrimination in housing. The Committee has also criticised the absence of statutory provisions explicitly prohibiting racial discrimination, the lack of effective remedies, and weak institutional enforcement mechanisms.¹⁴ In response, the Japanese government argued that the *Human Rights Bureau* within the *Ministry of Justice* engages in protecting human rights.¹⁵ While the Bureau, originally established in 1948, explicitly recognises nationality-based exclusion in the housing market as a human-rights issue, it lacks institutional independence from the government and does not possess binding enforcement powers.

2.3.2 Hate Speech Regulation without Criminal Sanction

Because perceptions of discrimination are often influenced not only by direct experiences but also by publicly expressed exclusionary attitudes, the Japanese legal and regulatory treatment of discriminatory speech is also relevant to the present study. Japan maintains reservations to Article 4(b) and (c) of CERD, which require the criminalisation of certain forms of hate speech and racist organisations, citing concerns regarding freedom of expression. The Committee has repeatedly expressed concerns regarding racist and xenophobic speech in Japan.¹⁶

In response to growing domestic and international criticism, Japan enacted the *Hate Speech Act 2016*.¹⁷ However, the Act has a limited scope and lacks enforcement structure. The definition of prohibited conduct is relatively narrow, requiring speech or behaviour intended to promote or induce discriminatory sentiments or discriminatory behaviour (Art 2). Moreover, the Act does not impose any sanctions, instead providing only that 'citizens of Japan shall endeavour to deepen their understanding of the need to eliminate unfair discriminatory speech or behaviour' (Art 3). While Japanese courts have, in some cases, awarded damages against hate speech both offline and online,¹⁸ the CERD Committee has continued to express concerns regarding

¹⁴See Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations of the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination: Japan*, CERD/C/304/Add.114 (2001), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=lyJrhoSIHCA2RTKXgko4JqwonaM2kkcNfU6wkv17W5MYLT%2Bv2S5EYH9NmA5629puv7EaR830WENKIUUL4jclH5tQi2u1ZbAKryD4rPoRvU8%3D>; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations of the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination: Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/3-6 (2010), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=izUhol7ZxPbJFSowm%2F1jbKdvAC70A0joqH39rxwD%2FsYQ80FqNjARt%2BgGI6FwhLsR%2BHO%2BiMsoHqxD9AuibXWA%3D%3D>; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations on the Combined Seventh to Ninth Periodic Reports of Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/7-9 (2014), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=eH37LT%2F%2BEGaGZEmrzoZ0Bddj8Jx71StPMHnyoeIwYtHVqaweoS%2F%2FM7RevYJU%2BKbVsT5V0FJoEqW2Avpbo%2FLTbw%3D%3D>; Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Concluding Observations on the Combined Tenth and Eleventh Periodic Reports of Japan*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/10-11 (2018), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=cSiLKueF08pNvNu3RBjBpHu596d6AmEKyPsxtP5iedXv%2F1H9b8G03JWV4wBKUZ2uVwJCQ%2FBBEpk4BWzF3NPswSunJWsZ8oB%2F6pY7tcdcw%3D>.

¹⁵Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination, *Information Received from Japan on Follow-up to the Concluding Observations*, CERD/C/JPN/CO/10-11/Add.1 (2019), available at: <https://docstore.ohchr.org/SelfServices/FilesHandler.ashx?enc=%2BTnmP2Rfpf5TFx0TwIkDW0rxS6g0v7bNqxQ1hx%2Fa6i%2F0TwwUXfnDt1habGcxZanbpGTH9jbsgcHLfAUyrQLW1NB%2Bon%2Fg3nSq7U0SnjG85zc%3D>

¹⁶See note 8.

¹⁷Act of the Promotion of Efforts to Eliminate Unfair Discriminatory Speech and Behaviour against Persons Originating from Outside Japan (2016).

¹⁸For instance, the Kyoto District Court (7 October 2013) awarded damages against an extremist anti-Korean organisation whose members repeatedly used loudspeakers near a Korean school to disseminate discriminatory and derogatory speech targeting ethnic Koreans. More recently, the Tokyo High Court (12 May 2021) awarded damages that were relatively high by Japanese tort law standards against a blogger, who had posted discriminatory and derogatory comments against ethnic Koreans.

the absence of effective anti-hate speech enforcement mechanisms in Japan.¹⁹

Taken together, Japan’s legal and institutional framework provides comparatively limited constraints on nationality-based exclusion in private rental markets. While courts have occasionally recognised particularly explicit forms of discrimination as unlawful, the absence of comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation and effective enforcement mechanisms leaves substantial discretion to landlords and real-estate agents in screening prospective tenants.

However, the Japanese government maintains that discrimination against non-Japanese residents was not sufficiently severe to require comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation or criminal sanctions. It stated that ‘We do not recognize that the present situation of Japan is one in which discriminative act cannot be effectively restrained by the existing legal system...’, thereby maintaining that the existing Japanese legal framework was sufficient to address discriminatory conduct without further legislative intervention.²⁰ The following section therefore examines whether exclusionary practices remain observable in Tokyo’s contemporary rental market.

3 Survey Design

3.1 Technical Implementation and Quality Assurance

We conducted a cross-sectional online survey between April and May 2025 using the Japanese panel provider *GM0 Research*. The survey targeted residents of the Greater Tokyo area and used quota sampling to recruit approximately 800 Japanese nationals and 200 foreign-born residents. Foreign-born respondents were oversampled to ensure sufficient power for subgroup analyses.

The questionnaire was implemented in Qualtrics and included standard data-quality safeguards, including minimum completion-time thresholds, response-completeness checks, location validation, and duplicate-response prevention. After applying these filters, a small number of observations was excluded due to incomplete or inconsistent responses. Further implementation details are reported in Appendix B. Ethical approval was obtained from the Department of Land Economy, and informed consent was secured from all participants prior to participation.

3.2 Development of Fictitious Rental Applicants

Applicant profiles were constructed using *Japanese Immigration Agency* (2024) data to reflect the composition of migrant inflows following the 2018 immigration reforms. To isolate perceived discrimination, profiles differed only in ethnically identifiable names, while all other applicant characteristics were held constant. Applicant names were pre-tested for ethnic recognisability and standardised using Japanese script conventions to preserve comparability across profiles. Table 1 reports the final applicant profiles.

The Western-Japanese profile is included to distinguish perceived responses to foreignness from responses to partial cultural or ethnic proximity. Unlike the Western profile, the Western-Japanese applicant combines a Western given name with a Japanese surname, thereby signalling both foreign association and potential insider status. This allows us to examine whether per-

¹⁹See *Concluding Observations on the Combined Tenth and Eleventh Periodic Reports of Japan* (2018), in note 11.

²⁰Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Japan, *Comments of the Japanese Government on the Concluding Observations Adopted by the Committee on the Elimination of Racial Discrimination on March 20, 2000, Regarding Initial and Second Periodic Report of the Japanese Government* (2000), available at: <https://www.mofa.go.jp/policy/human/comment0110.html>.

Table 1: Applicant Profiles

Name	Ethnicity	Native Translation	Katakana Characters
Taro Yamamoto	Japanese	山本太郎	山本太郎
Andi Surya Purta	Indonesian	Andi Surya Purta	アンディ・スルヤ・プトラ
Wei Chang	Chinese	张伟	ウェイ・チャン
Thomas Laurent	Western	Thomas Laurent	トーマ・ローラン
James Takeda	Western-Japanese	James Takeda	ジェームズ・武田
Nguyễn Văn Minh	Vietnamese	Nguyễn Văn Minh	グエン・ヴァン・ミン
Park-Ji Hoon	Korean	박지훈	パク・ジフン

Notes: Native scripts are shown where applicable; Katakana is used to standardise the rendering of non-Japanese names.

ceived rental access follows a binary Japanese/non-Japanese distinction or more graduated ethnic boundaries. Further details on name construction, validation procedures, script standardisation, and translation protocols are provided in Appendix C.

3.3 Questionnaire Design

The questionnaire comprised three sections. The first collected socio-economic characteristics. The second asked respondents to evaluate the likelihood that each applicant would secure a rental viewing for a standardised property. The third, administered only to foreign-born respondents, included a condensed version of the Everyday Discrimination Scale (Williams et al., 1997), adapted to capture experiences relevant to rental access and search strategies.

The survey was developed in English and translated into Japanese, followed by verification by four native speakers. Questions on socio-economic characteristics were drawn from established government sources.²¹ The main covariates include income, employment status, housing status, gender, age, ethnicity, and education. For foreign-born respondents, we additionally collect visa status, length of residence, and Japanese-language proficiency.

Perceived Likelihood of Securing a Rental Viewing. Respondents were shown a rental listing together with the applicant profiles described in subsection 3.2. For each profile, respondents stated the perceived likelihood that the applicant would be invited to a viewing. Respondents were also asked to assess the probability that they themselves would receive a viewing invitation. The same property listing was used throughout the experiment.

Perceived likelihoods were elicited on an 11-step scale, as illustrated in Figure 2. The property listing was sourced from *LIFULL Homes*,²² one of Japan’s largest real-estate platforms and the platform used by Sugasawa and Harano (2023). The selected property is a one-room apartment located in the Tokyo ward with the median number of foreign-born residents. The listing was chosen to match the profile of a single male applicant and to anchor respondents’ expectations in a realistic rental-search environment (Weiss and Roberts, 2018).

²¹The questions were taken from the *Ministry of Justice Basic Foreign Residents Survey* (<https://www.moj.go.jp/isa/content/001421198.pdf>), the *2020 National Census* (<https://www.stat.go.jp/english/data/kokusei/2020/summary.html>), and the *National Survey of Family Income, Consumption and Wealth* (<https://www.stat.go.jp/english/data/zenkokukakei/index.html>).

²²See <https://www.homes.co.jp/>.

Figure 2: Eliciting the Perceived Likelihood to be Invited

English (United Kingdom) ▾

PR
Rental Apartment
Village Enomoto 302/ 3rd floor

	Rent/management fee, etc. 60,000 yen -	Location 3-2-11 Minamidai, Nakano-ku, Tokyo	Transportation 12-minute walk from Nakano Fujimicho Station on the Tokyo Metro Marunouchi Line	Exclusive area/floor plan 15.71 square meters One room
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Wei Chang has just moved to Tokyo; he wants to rent the above property. He contacted the landlord and asked to view the property. What do you think is the chance of him being invited to a viewing?

0102030405060708090100

Chance of being invited for a viewing (%)

Notes: The figure shows a snapshot of the experimental screens presented to participants to elicit their subjective perceptions of the likelihood of being invited to a viewing.

Everyday Discrimination Scale. Foreign-born respondents were additionally asked four questions from the Everyday Discrimination Scale, reported in Appendix D. The items capture experiences of discourtesy, poorer service, being feared, and being viewed as dishonest. These dimensions are relevant to landlord and agent screening decisions in rental markets (Clark, 2007; Hamovitch et al., 2022; Hanson et al., 2011). Responses are coded on a linear scale from 5 (almost every day) to 0 (never) and averaged into a composite index of experienced everyday discrimination.

We use this measure to examine whether prior experiences of discrimination are associated with respondents’ perceived likelihood of securing a viewing invitation. We also relate the EDS score to integration-related variables, including permanent residency status, length of stay, and Japanese-language proficiency.

4 Empirical Analyses

4.1 Empirical Roadmap

In this section, we assess both the experimentally collected data²³ as well as further observational data strengthening external validity of our results.

We follow a concise evaluation strategy as summarised in Table 2. Our results are classified according to the evaluator and the object of evaluation. This classification structures the empirical analysis that follows. We first examine how foreign-born respondents evaluate the treatment of non-Japanese applicants, which we refer to as auto-stereotypes. We then examine how native Japanese respondents evaluate the treatment of the same non-Japanese applicants,

²³Table 12 in the Appendix reports summary statistics.

Table 2: Evaluation Strategy

	Foreign-born respondents	Section	Native Japanese respondents	Section
Prospects of non-Japanese applicants	Auto-stereotype	4.2	Hetero-stereotype	4.3
Own prospects	Personal evaluation	4.4	Native self-evaluation	4.4.2
<i>Derived Discrepancies</i>				
PGDD	Personal evaluation vs. auto-stereotype	4.4	–	–
GGDD	Auto-stereotype vs. hetero-stereotype	4.5	Auto-stereotype vs. hetero-stereotype	4.5
Benchmark self-evaluation gap	Personal evaluation vs. matched applicant profile	4.4.2	Native self-evaluation vs. Japanese applicant	4.4.2

Notes: PGDD denotes the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy and compares foreign-born respondents’ evaluations of their own prospects with their evaluations of the prospects of non-Japanese applicants. GGDD denotes the Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy and compares foreign-born and native Japanese respondents’ evaluations of the prospects of the same non-Japanese applicants. Native Japanese self-evaluations are used as a benchmark for general self-optimism, comparing native Japanese respondents’ own expected viewing probability with their evaluation of the Japanese applicant.

which we refer to as hetero-stereotypes.

We next compare foreign-born respondents’ evaluations of their own prospects with their evaluations of the prospects of matched non-Japanese applicants. This comparison corresponds to the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (PGDD). To assess whether this pattern reflects a minority-specific personal-group discrepancy rather than a general tendency toward favourable self-assessment, we also compare the foreign-born matched self-gap with the corresponding native Japanese self-gap. Finally, we compare foreign-born and native Japanese respondents’ evaluations of the disadvantage faced by the same non-Japanese applicants. We refer to this comparison as the Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (GGDD).

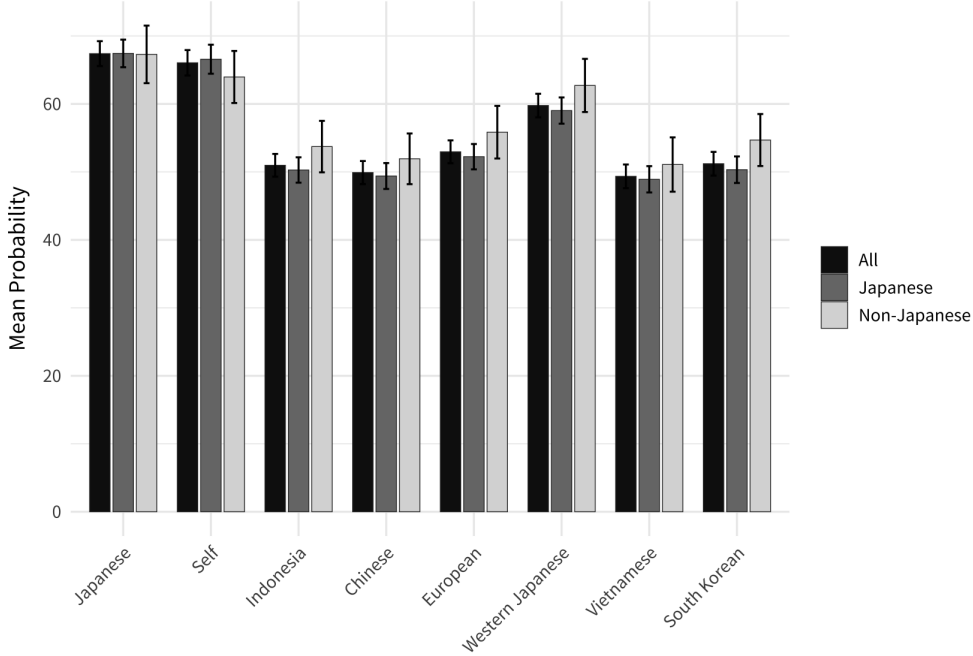
4.2 Auto-stereotypes of Foreign Disadvantage

We begin by examining auto-stereotypes, that is, foreign-born respondents’ perceptions of the treatment of non-Japanese applicants. Across all applicant profiles, foreign-born respondents assign lower viewing probabilities to non-Japanese applicants than to the otherwise identical Japanese applicant (see Figure 3). The perceived penalties range from 4.6 percentage points for the Western-Japanese applicant to 16.2 percentage points for the Vietnamese applicant, with all differences statistically significant at the 1 per cent level.

To assess the substantive magnitude of these perceived disadvantages, we compute Cohen’s d relative to the Japanese benchmark. The resulting effect sizes are moderate for most non-Japanese applicants. Chinese and Indonesian applicants are evaluated 0.59 and 0.55 standard deviations below the Japanese benchmark, respectively, while the Vietnamese applicant displays a similarly large effect size ($d = 0.57$). By contrast, the Western-Japanese applicant yields a substantially smaller effect size ($d = 0.21$). These estimates indicate that foreign-born respondents themselves perceive meaningful disadvantages facing non-Japanese applicants in Tokyo’s rental market. At the same time, the comparatively small penalty for the Western-

Japanese applicant suggests that perceived disadvantage is not organised solely around a binary Japanese/non-Japanese distinction. Instead, foreign-born respondents appear to perceive gradations in rental-market access, with profiles signalling partial cultural proximity to the Japanese majority evaluated more favourably than other non-Japanese profiles.

Figure 3: Mean stated viewing probabilities.



Notes: Collectively stated average probabilities of applicants of different ethnic backgrounds being offered a viewing. Overall probabilities as well as splits by native Japanese and foreign-born participants. Bars indicate standard deviations.

4.3 Hetero-stereotypes of Foreign Disadvantage

Assessing the remaining profiles, Figure 3 reveals that Japanese respondents expect *all* non-Japanese applicants to face a significantly lower probability of securing a viewing invitation than the Japanese applicant, with all differences statistically significant at the 1 per cent level. Among Japanese respondents, effect sizes are moderate to large ($d > 0.5$), with Indonesian and Chinese applicants positioned 0.71 and 0.67 standard deviations below the Japanese benchmark, respectively.

The largest perceived disadvantages are observed for Vietnamese, Chinese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, while the Western applicant is evaluated somewhat more favourably. The Western-Japanese applicant receives the most favourable evaluation among all non-Japanese profiles.

4.4 Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (PGDD)

4.4.1 Discrepancy in Perceived Magnitude of Disadvantage

We next examine how individuals perceive the group-level disadvantage and their own disadvantage. As motivated in subsection 3.3, we test whether individuals differentiate between an-

ticipated group-level discrimination and their own expected treatment, following PGDD (Dion, 2001). Specifically, we examine whether respondents assign lower probabilities of securing a viewing to their ethnic group in general than to themselves.

The classic PGDD pattern is summarised by Taylor et al. (1996) as “perceiving my group, but not myself,” or by McAvay and Safi (2025) as “I’m fine, but my group is not.” The native Japanese benchmark helps clarify the interpretation of this pattern. Native Japanese respondents do not evaluate their own prospects significantly more favourably than those of the Japanese applicant. By contrast, foreign-born respondents with a matched applicant profile report a large and statistically significant self-evaluation gap. This comparison suggests that the PGDD result is not simply a manifestation of general self-optimism in the survey task. Rather, the personal-group discrepancy is concentrated among foreign-born respondents, strengthening the interpretation that personal and collective perceptions of minority disadvantage are structured differently.

To analyse this, we regress participants’ self-perceived likelihood of securing a viewing on the probability they attribute to applicants of their own nationality. The analysis focuses on respondents for whom a corresponding nationality profile is available, namely Japanese, Vietnamese, Chinese, South Korean, and Indonesian applicants. Under the hypothesis of optimistic self-assessment relative to the group, the coefficient on the matched nationality profile should be strictly smaller than one.

Table 3 reports the results across six specifications. Models (1), (3), and (5) estimate log-log specifications, while models (2), (4), and (6) present results in levels. Across all specifications (1)–(6), the coefficient on the matched nationality profile is positive, highly statistically significant, and consistently below one, ranging from 0.643 to 0.647 in the log-log models and from 0.722 to 0.739 in the linear models. Indeed, in all specifications, the coefficient on the matched nationality profile is significantly smaller than one ($p < 0.001$), providing strong support for the hypothesis that respondents evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of their nationality group.²⁴

This pattern provides strong and robust support for the hypothesis: respondents systematically rate their own chances of receiving a viewing invitation more favourably than those of applicants from their own nationality group.

The magnitude of the coefficient further suggests that while group-level perceptions strongly shape individual expectations, they are not translated one-to-one. Instead, individuals exhibit a clear optimism bias, discounting the degree of discrimination faced by their broader group when assessing their own prospects.

This result is stable across specifications. Models (1) and (2), which include nationality fixed effects, yield nearly identical coefficients to models (3) and (4), where these fixed effects are omitted but individual controls are introduced. Adding socioeconomic controls—such as log income and education—in models (3) and (4), and jointly with nationality fixed effects in models (5) and (6), leaves the coefficient on the matched nationality profile virtually unchanged. This indicates that the observed gap between individual and group-level expectations is not driven by observable characteristics such as income or education.

²⁴We test $H_0 : \beta = 1$ against the one-sided alternative $H_1 : \beta < 1$, using $t = (\hat{\beta} - 1)/SE(\hat{\beta})$. The null is rejected in all specifications (1)–(6), with test statistics of $t = -14.86$ in (1), -10.73 in (2), -15.22 in (3), -11.73 in (4), -15.17 in (5), and -11.14 in (6) (all $p < 0.001$).

4.4.2 Robustness to Socio-Economic Characteristics

The relationship between group-level and personal expectations remains stable after accounting for respondents' socio-economic characteristics. Returning to the regression specifications in Table 3, the coefficient on the matched nationality profile is nearly unchanged when individual controls are added. This indicates that the observed gap between personal and group-level expectations is not driven by observable characteristics such as income or education. Among the control variables, higher income is positively and significantly associated with more optimistic self-assessed viewing probabilities in models (3)–(6). The effect of education is positive but weaker and less robust across specifications. Nationality fixed effects in models (1), (2), (5), and (6) reveal level differences across groups, but do not alter the central relationship of interest. Overall, these results suggest that the personal-group discrepancy is not simply an artefact of socio-economic composition across respondent groups.

4.4.3 Native Self-Evaluation as a Benchmark

The preceding analyses show that respondents evaluate their own prospects differently from the prospects of the matched applicant profile, and that this relationship is robust to socio-economic controls. To assess whether this pattern reflects a minority-specific personal-group discrepancy or a more general tendency toward favourable self-assessment, we use native Japanese respondents as a benchmark.

Specifically, for native Japanese respondents, we define the benchmark gap as the respondent's self-assessed viewing likelihood minus the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant. For foreign-born respondents, we define the corresponding matched self-evaluation gap as the respondent's self-assessed viewing likelihood minus the stated viewing likelihood of the applicant profile corresponding to the respondent's nationality, where available.

Table 4 reports the results. Among native Japanese respondents, the mean self-evaluation gap is small and statistically insignificant, at -0.95 percentage points (p -value= 0.230). Thus, native Japanese respondents do not rate their own prospects more favourably than those of the otherwise identical Japanese applicant. By contrast, among foreign-born respondents with a matched applicant profile, the mean self-evaluation gap is 9.10 percentage points and highly statistically significant (p -value < 0.001). The difference between the foreign-born and native Japanese gaps is 10.06 percentage points (p -value < 0.001).

These results suggest that the personal-group discrepancy documented above is not simply driven by a general tendency for respondents to evaluate themselves more favourably than comparable applicants. Instead, the self-evaluation gap is concentrated among foreign-born respondents. The benchmark therefore strengthens the interpretation of the result as a minority-specific personal-group discrepancy.

4.4.4 The Role of Foreign-Born Respondents' Own Experience of Discrimination

Additional questions elicit foreign-born respondents' self-reported experiences of discrimination ($N = 195$ valid), as detailed in subsection 3.3. Respondents are presented with four scenarios capturing how others behave towards them in different contexts. Responses are coded such that lower values correspond to more frequent experiences of unequal treatment. In addition to examining each dimension separately, we construct an individual-level index of experienced discriminatory behaviour by averaging responses across the four scenarios.

As shown in Figure 8 in the Appendix, only a small fraction of foreign-born respondents report never having experienced discriminatory behaviour. The modal response across all scenarios

Table 3: Group Perceptions vs. Individual Expectations

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Log-log	Linear	Log-log	Linear	Log-log	Linear
Intercept	0.224 (0.401)	-6.537 (12.062)	1.236*** (0.102)	12.300*** (2.059)	-0.037 (0.400)	-15.042 (12.027)
Matched nationality profile	0.647*** (0.024)	0.739*** (0.024)	0.643*** (0.023)	0.722*** (0.024)	0.643*** (0.024)	0.732*** (0.024)
Vietnam	1.238*** (0.461)	22.346 (13.981)			1.321*** (0.456)	24.994* (13.810)
China	1.417*** (0.406)	32.978*** (12.286)			1.488*** (0.402)	34.893*** (12.144)
Japan	1.164*** (0.400)	23.199* (12.132)			1.259*** (0.396)	26.159** (11.992)
South Korea	1.233*** (0.419)	25.352** (12.677)			1.299*** (0.414)	27.324** (12.522)
Log income			0.097*** (0.026)	2.801*** (0.794)	0.102*** (0.026)	2.921*** (0.790)
Degree			0.082* (0.049)	3.820** (1.497)	0.063 (0.050)	3.085** (1.498)
Nationality FE	✓	✓			✓	✓
SE Controls			✓	✓	✓	✓
Adj. R^2	0.462	0.513	0.465	0.518	0.474	0.525
F -statistic	155.50***	190.20***	261.80***	322.50***	116.90***	143.10***
Observations	900	900	900	900	900	900

Notes: The dependent variable is respondents' self-perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation. In log-log models, the dependent variable and matched nationality profile are transformed as $\log(1 + x)$. The matched nationality profile is the perceived viewing likelihood for the applicant profile corresponding to the respondent's own nationality. The omitted nationality category is Indonesia. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

is “A few times a month” (see Table 5), indicating that recurring exposure to subtle forms of discrimination is common within the sample. These items capture everyday instances of unequal treatment adapted to the housing context and are expected to be closely related to respondents' perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation.

To examine this relationship, we first estimate bivariate correlations between the stated probability of securing a viewing and the composite discrimination index. We find a positive yet modest correlation (Spearman's $\rho = 0.125$, $H_0 : \rho = 0$ vs. $H_1 : \rho > 0$ rejects H_0 with p -value = 0.041), indicating that stated perceived viewing likelihoods capture a related—though not identical—construct to broader measures of perceived discrimination. Repeating this test separately for each discrimination dimension reveals that no individual component is, in isolation, statistically significantly correlated with the subjectively stated viewing probability. This suggests that the observed association reflects the combined effect of multiple dimensions of perceived discrimination rather than any single category alone.

Next, we regress the stated probability of securing a viewing on the composite discrimination index and incrementally add further controls. We also test for a non-linear relationship between the two factors. Table 6 shows that respondents' perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation is systematically associated with their prior experiences of discrimination. Across all six specifications (1)–(6), the EDS score enters positively and is highly statistically significant, while its squared term is negative and statistically significant throughout, confirming a robust nonlinear relationship. This implies that respondents with more frequent prior discrimination

Table 4: Self-Evaluation Benchmark

	<i>N</i>	Mean gap	SE	<i>t</i> -statistic	<i>p</i> -value
Native Japanese	773	-0.95	0.79	-1.20	0.230
Foreign-born	127	9.10***	2.08	4.39	< 0.001
Difference: foreign-born – native Japanese	900	10.06***	2.13	4.72	< 0.001

Notes: The gap is defined as respondents’ self-assessed viewing probability minus their evaluation of the matched applicant profile. For native Japanese respondents, the matched profile is the Japanese applicant. For foreign-born respondents, the matched profile is the applicant corresponding to the respondent’s nationality, where available. The difference is estimated from a regression of the self-evaluation gap on an indicator for foreign-born respondents.

Table 5: Most Frequent Response for Each EDS Item

Question	Most frequent response	<i>n</i>	%
EDS1	A few times a month	68	34.2
EDS2	A few times a month	85	42.7
EDS3	A few times a month	107	53.8
EDS4	A few times a month	119	59.8

Notes: Entries report the modal response category for each EDS item. Percentages are the share of responses for that item selecting the modal category.

experiences (i.e., lower EDS scores) report lower expected probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation, whereas those who report less frequent discrimination express more optimistic expectations. The negative coefficient on the squared term further suggests diminishing marginal effects: the positive association between more favourable past treatment and perceived viewing chances weakens at higher levels of the EDS index.

Furthermore, we examine whether integration into Japanese society is associated with individuals’ perceived success in the housing application process. Integration is proxied by permanent residency status, length of stay in Japan, and self-reported Japanese language proficiency. Length of stay, included in specifications (4) and (6), is statistically insignificant in both models, suggesting that time spent in Japan does not meaningfully explain variation in perceived probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation. Japanese language proficiency, introduced in specifications (2) and (6), is positively associated with perceived success and weakly significant in specification (2); however, the effect becomes statistically insignificant in specification (6) once additional controls are included, indicating limited robustness. Permanent residency status, included in specifications (3) and (6), also remains positive but statistically insignificant throughout.

In contrast, economic resources appear to matter. Log income, included in specifications (5) and (6), enters positively and is statistically significant in both models, suggesting that higher-income respondents report more optimistic expectations regarding their rental prospects.

Overall, while the models explain only a limited share of the variation in perceived viewing probabilities (adjusted R^2 ranging from 0.035 to 0.065 across specifications (1)–(6)), they consistently indicate that prior experiences of discrimination are a key determinant of respondents’ expectations. Income also plays a meaningful role, whereas conventional indicators of integration—such as language proficiency, visa status, and length of stay—show limited and non-robust associations. By contrast, perceptions of group-level success, namely the collective

Table 6: Determinants of Respondents' Perceived Own Likelihood of Receiving a Viewing Invitation

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	41.045*** (8.864)	27.784** (11.265)	38.136*** (9.054)	37.077*** (12.427)	32.674*** (9.463)	23.362* (13.524)
EDS score	20.550*** (6.735)	18.542*** (6.775)	19.667*** (6.741)	20.950*** (6.806)	21.081*** (6.662)	18.440*** (6.853)
EDS score ²	-3.999*** (1.281)	-3.439*** (1.307)	-3.781*** (1.286)	-4.078*** (1.295)	-4.092*** (1.267)	-3.406** (1.328)
Language skills		1.441* (0.764)				1.166 (0.783)
Permanent visa			5.832 (3.953)			4.503 (4.035)
Length of stay				0.565 (1.238)		-0.396 (1.272)
Log income					4.897** (2.090)	4.382** (2.111)
Adj. R^2	0.039	0.051	0.045	0.035	0.061	0.065
F -statistic	4.91***	4.50***	4.02***	3.33**	5.18***	3.25***
Observations	195	195	195	195	195	195

Notes: The dependent variable is respondents' perceived own likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation. *EDS score* measures the frequency with which respondents report having experienced discriminatory behaviour. *Language skills* is defined as the sum of reading and speaking ability. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

perceived success of foreign-born respondents in the Japanese housing market, appear to be more strongly associated with perceived individual outcomes. Taken together, these findings suggest that subjective expectations in the rental housing market are shaped less by individuals' own integration characteristics and more by broader perceptions of how foreign-born respondents are treated within Japanese society, with economic resources playing a secondary but still important role.

4.4.5 Summary of PGDD

Overall, the findings provide strong evidence of a systematic personal-group discrepancy among foreign-born respondents. Foreign-born respondents recognise nationality-based disadvantage in the rental market, but they evaluate their own prospects more favourably than those of the matched applicant profile representing their broader nationality group. This pattern is robust across specifications and is not explained by observable characteristics such as income, education, or nationality fixed effects.

The native Japanese benchmark further clarifies the interpretation of this result. Native Japanese respondents do not rate their own prospects significantly more favourably than those of the Japanese applicant. By contrast, foreign-born respondents with a matched applicant profile report a large and statistically significant self-evaluation gap. This suggests that the documented discrepancy is not merely a general tendency toward favourable self-assessment. Rather, it appears to be concentrated among foreign-born respondents and is therefore consistent with the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (PGDD).

Subsequent analyses show that foreign-born respondents' expectations are also related to prior experiences of everyday discrimination. Respondents reporting more frequent discriminatory treatment express more pessimistic expectations about their own rental prospects.

Economic resources, proxied by income, are also positively associated with perceived access, while conventional integration indicators such as language proficiency, permanent residency status, and length of stay are less robust predictors in these specifications.

Taken together, the PGDD results suggest that perceptions of rental-market disadvantage operate at both collective and personal levels. Foreign-born respondents recognise disadvantages facing their nationality group, but they do not fully translate these group-level expectations into their own anticipated outcomes. This divergence may reflect cognitive mechanisms commonly discussed in the PGDD literature, but it may also reflect behavioural adaptation, selective optimism, or individual strategies for navigating perceived market barriers.

4.5 Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (GGDD)

4.5.1 Discrepancy in Perceived Magnitude of Disadvantage

While both foreign-born (auto-stereotype) and native Japanese respondents (hetero-stereotype) perceive substantial disadvantages facing non-Japanese applicants, the magnitude of the perceived penalty is consistently larger among native Japanese respondents.

The estimates in Figure 3 indicate that Japanese respondents perceive stronger disadvantages for non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents. Consistent with these univariate comparisons, the results indicate that native respondents assign even lower likelihood to non-Japanese applicants. Model (2) confirms again that Japanese respondents perceive a significantly larger penalty for non-Japanese applicants than non-Japanese respondents.

While conceptually related to the PGDD, this phenomenon concerns a different comparison. Both involve divergences in perceptions of disadvantage. However, whereas PGDD compares perceptions of personal disadvantage with perceptions of disadvantage facing one's own group, the present phenomenon compares perceptions of disadvantage facing the same minority group across majority and minority respondents. To the best of our knowledge, this angle has not been studied before and we hence introduce a new term: *Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy* (GGDD).

4.5.2 Gradation of Disadvantage

Beyond the overall magnitude of perceived disadvantage, GGDD may also be reflected in the way respondents map disadvantage across minority groups. The relative hierarchy assigned to different applicant profiles provides insight into how majority and minority respondents draw the social boundaries separating majority and minority groups. We therefore examine the relative hierarchy assigned to different applicant profiles.

Splitting responses by applicants' ethnic background reveals substantial heterogeneity, as shown in Figure 3. Japanese respondents expect all non-Japanese applicants to face a significantly lower probability of receiving a viewing invitation than the Japanese applicant, with all differences statistically significant at the 1% level. The largest perceived disadvantages are observed for Vietnamese, Chinese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, while the Western applicant is evaluated somewhat more favourably. The Western-Japanese applicant receives the most favourable evaluation among all non-Japanese profiles. This pattern suggests that perceived housing access is shaped not only by foreignness itself but also by signals of cultural proximity and partial insider status.

Assessing the relative ranking of applicant groups, native Japanese and foreign-born respondents exhibit broad agreement regarding the most favourably evaluated categories. Differences between the two groups emerge only among the lowest-ranked categories. Japanese respondents rank Chinese applicants above Vietnamese and Indonesian applicants, assigning Indonesians the lowest position overall. In contrast, foreign-born respondents rank Indonesians above Vietnamese and Chinese applicants, while Chinese applicants receive the lowest ranking in this group.

Nationality-specific analyses reported in Table 13 in the Appendix reveal substantial heterogeneity within the foreign-born sample. While respondents differ considerably in their relative evaluations of Chinese, Vietnamese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, the comparatively favourable assessment of the Western-Japanese applicant is remarkably consistent across respondent nationalities. Overall, these findings suggest that perceived housing access is structured less by a universally shared hierarchy among foreign groups than by broad distinctions in perceived cultural proximity and insider status. The stable advantage attributed to the Western-Japanese profile therefore suggests that respondents perceive access through graded boundaries of belonging rather than a simple Japanese/non-Japanese divide.²⁵

Table 7: Differences in Perceived Likelihood of Viewing Invitations by Origin

	Indonesian	Chinese	Western Nationals	Western Japanese	Vietnamese	South Korean	Self- Perceived
Japanese							
Probability (%)	50.28	49.40	52.24	59.03	48.91	50.33	66.58
Difference from Japanese (%)	-17.12***	-17.90***	-15.16***	-8.44***	-18.59***	-17.18***	-0.95
Cohen's <i>d</i>	0.71	0.67	0.62	0.40	0.69	0.65	0.04
<i>N</i>	788	785	783	780	776	772	773
Non-Japanese							
Probability (%)	53.73	51.93	55.85	62.72	51.09	54.69	63.97
Difference from Japanese (%)	-13.57***	-15.57***	-11.48***	-4.61***	-16.24***	-12.64***	-3.36
Cohen's <i>d</i>	0.55	0.59	0.45	0.21	0.57	0.47	0.11
<i>N</i>	198	197	195	195	195	195	195

Notes: Entries report paired comparisons between the Japanese applicant (Taro Yamamoto) and each target applicant. “Probability” gives the mean perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation for the target applicant. “Difference from Japanese” is calculated as target applicant probability minus Japanese applicant probability; negative values therefore indicate a lower perceived likelihood than for the Japanese applicant. Cohen's *d* is based on the paired difference between the Japanese applicant and the target applicant. *N* varies slightly across comparisons because each estimate uses respondents with complete paired responses for the relevant applicant pair. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

As shown in Figure 4, all non-Japanese profiles are evaluated less favourably than the Japanese benchmark. The most striking feature of the ranking is the stable position of the Western-Japanese applicant immediately below the Japanese benchmark in both respondent groups, making it the highest-ranked non-Japanese profile. Both groups further evaluate the Western applicant and the South Korean applicant relatively favourably compared with the remaining non-Japanese categories.

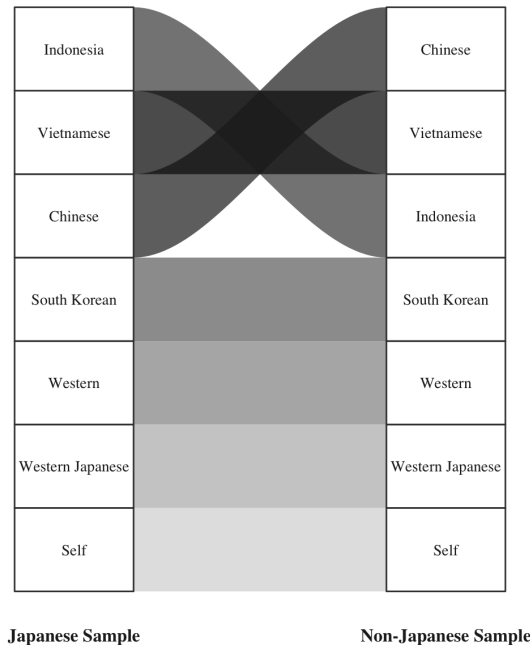
²⁵As an additional robustness check, we reweighted the full sample so that the nationality composition of survey respondents matches the corresponding population shares of Tokyo residents by nationality, using data from the Tokyo Statistical Yearbook (2024), <https://www.toukei.metro.tokyo.lg.jp/tnenkan/2024/t24q3e002.htm>. The resulting estimates are qualitatively identical to those obtained for the native population. This similarity is unsurprising given the relatively small share of foreign residents in Tokyo. Consequently, the results based on the native population provide a close approximation to the perceptions of Tokyo's population as a whole.

The Western-Japanese profile combines a Western given name with a Japanese surname, signalling both foreign association and partial insider status. The comparatively favourable evaluation of the Western-Japanese applicant is theoretically important because it suggests that perceived rental access is not governed solely by a binary distinction between Japanese and non-Japanese applicants (see also Pager and Shepherd, 2008). Rather, respondents appear to distinguish between varying degrees of cultural proximity and social closeness to the Japanese majority. This pattern is consistent with research showing that discrimination often operates through socially graded boundaries of perceived cultural proximity and assimilability rather than through simple majority-minority distinctions.

Differences between the two groups emerge only among the lowest-ranked categories. Japanese respondents rank Chinese applicants above Vietnamese and Indonesian applicants, assigning Indonesians the lowest position overall. In contrast, foreign-born respondents rank Indonesians above Vietnamese and Chinese applicants, while Chinese applicants receive the lowest ranking in this group.

Nationality-specific analyses reported in Table 13 in the Appendix reveal substantial heterogeneity within the foreign-born sample. While respondents differ considerably in their relative evaluations of Chinese, Vietnamese, Indonesian, and South Korean applicants, the comparatively favourable assessment of the Western-Japanese applicant is remarkably consistent across respondent nationalities. Overall, these findings suggest that perceived housing access is structured less by a universally shared hierarchy among foreign groups than by broad distinctions in perceived cultural proximity and insider status. The stable advantage attributed to the Western-Japanese profile therefore suggests that respondents perceive access through graded boundaries of belonging rather than a simple Japanese/non-Japanese divide.

Figure 4: Ranking Shifts in Cohen’s d by Origin



Notes: Rankings are based on Cohen’s d from paired comparisons between the Japanese applicant and each comparison profile in perceived likelihood of viewing an invitation. Rank 1 (at the bottom) indicates the smallest negative deviation. The left column shows native Japanese respondents; the right column shows non-Japanese respondents.

In addition to the univariate comparisons, we test for systematic differences in a multivariate

Table 8: Perceived Likelihood of Viewing Invitations

	(1)	(2)	(3)
Constant	67.406*** (0.935)		
Chinese	-17.500*** (0.851)	-17.387*** (0.849)	-15.458*** (1.891)
Western Nationals	-14.446*** (0.799)	-14.349*** (0.793)	-11.401*** (1.830)
Indonesia	-16.430*** (0.776)	-16.407*** (0.775)	-13.566*** (1.763)
South Korean	-16.199*** (0.857)	-16.117*** (0.848)	-12.555*** (1.929)
Vietnamese	-18.055*** (0.878)	-17.999*** (0.870)	-16.160*** (2.041)
Western-Japanese	-7.639*** (0.684)	-7.580*** (0.675)	-4.524*** (1.540)
Self	-1.348* (0.779)	-1.308* (0.771)	-3.278 (2.171)
Chinese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-2.414 (2.116)
Western $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.686* (2.030)
Indonesia $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.555* (1.962)
South Korean $\times$ Japanese respondent			-4.458** (2.147)
Vietnamese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-2.300 (2.256)
Western-Japanese $\times$ Japanese respondent			-3.821** (1.713)
Self $\times$ Japanese respondent			2.470 (2.312)
Respondent FE	.	✓	✓
Clustered SE by respondent	✓	✓	✓
Adj. R^2	0.058	0.079	0.082
F -statistic	69.16***	238.85***	121.70***
Observations	7820	7820	7820

Notes: The dependent variable is the stated perceived likelihood of receiving a viewing invitation. The reference applicant is the Japanese applicant, Taro Yamamoto. Columns (2) and (3) include respondent fixed effects, absorbing respondent-specific baseline levels in stated probabilities. Standard errors, reported in parentheses, are clustered at the respondent level in all specifications. * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

regression framework (Table 8). Model (1) regresses stated viewing probabilities on applicant-profile indicators, with the Japanese applicant serving as the reference category. The estimated coefficients closely mirror the averages reported in Table 7. Since each respondent evaluates multiple applicant profiles, standard errors are clustered at the respondent level throughout.

Model (2) adds respondent fixed effects. This specification absorbs respondent-specific baseline differences in stated probabilities, such as a general tendency to assign higher or lower viewing chances across all profiles. The coefficients are therefore identified from within-respondent differences in perceived access across applicant profiles. The inclusion of respondent fixed effects leaves the estimated applicant-profile penalties virtually unchanged, reinforcing the robustness of the main finding that all non-Japanese profiles are perceived to face lower access probabilities than the Japanese benchmark.

Model (3) interacts the applicant-profile indicators with an indicator for native Japanese respondents. This specification tests whether native Japanese and foreign-born respondents differ in the perceived penalties they assign to the same applicant profiles. A Wald test rejects the joint null that all interaction terms are zero, indicating that perceived applicant-profile penalties differ systematically across respondent groups ($\chi^2_7 = 27.006$, $p = 0.0003$).

Consistent with the univariate comparisons in Table 7, native Japanese respondents generally assign larger penalties to non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents. The additional penalty is most clearly visible for South Korean and Western-Japanese applicants, where the interaction terms are statistically significant at conventional levels. The interactions for Western and Indonesian applicants are negative and weakly significant, while the differences for Chinese and Vietnamese applicants are not statistically significant. Thus, the evidence suggests that majority and minority respondents broadly agree that non-Japanese applicants face disadvantages, but differ in the magnitude of these perceived disadvantages for selected profiles.

The Western-Japanese applicant is particularly informative. Foreign-born respondents evaluate this profile relatively close to the Japanese benchmark, whereas native Japanese respondents assign a significantly larger penalty. This suggests that native respondents may perceive partial foreignness more sharply, even when the applicant also signals cultural proximity through a Japanese surname. South Korean applicants also occupy an intermediate position in the perceived hierarchy: they are evaluated less favourably than Western-Japanese and Western applicants, but more favourably than Chinese, Vietnamese, and Indonesian applicants. This pattern may reflect the coexistence of cultural familiarity and historically strained relations between Japan and South Korea.

Taken together, the regression results indicate a substantial degree of agreement between native Japanese and foreign-born respondents regarding the relative ordering of applicant profiles. Both groups place the Western-Japanese applicant closest to the Japanese benchmark and assign the largest penalties to other non-Japanese profiles. The principal difference between the two respondent groups therefore lies less in a fundamentally different perceived hierarchy than in the magnitude of the disadvantage attributed to particular applicant profiles. This pattern is consistent with the Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy: majority and minority respondents recognise the same broad structure of disadvantage, but differ in how strongly they perceive it.

4.5.3 The Role of Respondents' Socio-Economic Characteristics

Having established the existence and structure of GGDD, we next investigate whether respondents' characteristics, namely, their socio-economic statuses, are systematically associated with

Table 9: Heterogeneity Results

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
Intercept	67.406*** (0.934)	67.293*** (2.158)	66.201*** (1.253)	64.805*** (1.344)	68.010*** (1.355)	64.165*** (1.547)
NJA	-15.046*** (0.739)	-12.301*** (1.658)	-14.701*** (0.995)	-13.352*** (1.042)	-16.487*** (1.037)	-12.656*** (1.234)
Japanese respondent		0.141 (2.393)				
NJA $\times$ Japanese respondent		-3.434* (1.851)				
Female			2.911 (1.873)			
NJA $\times$ Female			-0.828 (1.478)			
Age > 50				5.263** (1.860)		
NJA $\times$ (Age > 50)				-3.504** (1.474)		
Income = Below Median					-1.189 (1.870)	
NJA $\times$ (Income = Below Median)					2.842* (1.474)	
Degree						5.417** (1.932)
NJA $\times$ Degree						-4.005** (1.533)
Clustered SE by Respondents	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Adj. R^2	0.035	0.036	0.036	0.037	0.035	0.036
F -statistic	248.80***	87.47***	86.58***	88.26***	84.85***	87.30***
Observations	6852	6852	6852	6845	6852	6852

Notes: The reference category for *NJA* is the Japanese applicant (Taro Yamamoto). * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

their evaluations of disadvantage facing non-Japanese applicants.

To focus on the overall perception of minority disadvantage, we next collapse all non-Japanese profiles into a single ‘Non-Japanese Applicants’ (NJA) category and examine heterogeneity by respondents’ characteristics. Table 9 reports the results.²⁶ Model (1) reaffirms the baseline findings obtained with separate non-Japanese applicant categories: Participants jointly expect a lower chance of NJAs to secure a viewing as compared to the Japanese applicant. Model (2) confirms again that Japanese respondents perceive a significantly larger penalty for non-Japanese applicants than non-Japanese respondents. Model (3) tests for differences by gender. Perceived discrimination appears not to differ between female and male participants.

Model (4) splits the sample at the median age. Older respondents expect higher viewing probabilities overall, but they also perceive a significantly larger disadvantage for NJAs. The findings for gender and age are in line with results from Luxembourg based on revealed discrimination rather than stated perceptions (Lepinteur et al., 2025). The finding that older Japanese participants perceive stronger disadvantages for NJAs may be driven by several mechanisms. The age gradient may reflect experience-based learning, cohort effects, or differential exposure to recent market developments. Distinguishing between these mechanisms is beyond the scope of the present design and remains an avenue for future research.

Model (5) indicates that lower-income respondents anticipate less discrimination against NJAs, implying that higher-income respondents perceive a stronger penalty. Model (6) distinguishes respondents by educational attainment (degree vs. no degree). Respondents with a degree perceive a larger disadvantage for non-Japanese applicants.

Compared with results for Luxembourg by Lepinteur et al. (2025), our findings show both clear parallels and some differences across the heterogeneity dimensions examined. Most importantly, Models (3) and (4) align with their results in showing no meaningful heterogeneity by gender and stronger perceived discrimination among older respondents. However, Model (6) reveals a different education gradient: whereas Lepinteur et al. (2025) find stronger discrimination among less-educated participants, our results suggest that respondents with a degree perceive a larger disadvantage for non-Japanese applicants.

To further investigate the education effect in Model (6), we estimate the specification on subsamples defined by participants’ nationality. When including participants from Asian countries with comparatively strong education systems (Japan, China, Taiwan, and South Korea), the estimated interaction effect remains qualitatively similar but becomes smaller in magnitude.

We further test whether restricting the sample to native Japanese or foreign-born respondents alters the effects in Models (2)–(6). The results remain quite stable across these restricted samples, and we do not find substantially different estimates when focusing on either group separately.

Overall, respondent characteristics are systematically associated with the perceived magnitude of disadvantage attributed to non-Japanese applicants. Older respondents, higher-income respondents, and respondents with a university degree consistently assign larger disadvantages to non-Japanese applicants, whereas the estimated effects are otherwise stable across respondent subgroups.

²⁶We cluster standard errors at the respondent-level. Controlling for individual FE again leads to very similar marginal effects.

4.5.4 The Role of Foreign-Born Respondents' Linguistic Proficiency

We next examine whether GGDD varies systematically with foreign-born respondents' Japanese language proficiency. Specifically, we calculate the gap between the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant and the average stated viewing likelihood of non-Japanese applicants, excluding the respondent's own profile type and the Western-Japanese profile.²⁷ Larger values indicate a larger perceived Japanese-applicant advantage.

The results suggest a threshold pattern rather than a smooth linear association (see Appendix E.1 for details). Respondents in the lowest Japanese-proficiency categories perceive substantially smaller Japanese-applicant advantages than other foreign-born respondents. For reading, the lowest-proficiency group reports an average gap of -7.52 percentage points, compared with 14.89 points among all other respondents. Similar low-proficiency contrasts appear for speaking and for the combined reading-speaking score. Once the lowest-proficiency group is excluded, the remaining correlation is small and statistically insignificant. These results provide suggestive, qualified support for the linguistic-asymmetry interpretation: Japanese-language access appears most relevant at the lower end of the proficiency distribution, rather than operating as a general linear relationship across all levels of proficiency.

As a complementary test, we use a fixed Japanese–Chinese comparison. This provides a cleaner comparison because the non-Japanese reference applicant is held constant, avoiding changes in the outcome that may arise from averaging across heterogeneous foreign applicant profiles. The comparison is also substantively important. Chinese-origin respondents constitute the largest group among foreign-born participants in our sample, accounting for 44.8 per cent of foreign-born respondents. Chinese nationals also represent 38.0 per cent of Tokyo's registered foreign population, making them the largest foreign nationality group in the city.²⁸ Moreover, Chinese nationals form the largest group of foreign new arrivals in the migration data used to construct the applicant profiles. The Japanese–Chinese comparison therefore captures both a central minority group in Tokyo's rental market and, for Chinese respondents, an own-group evaluation relative to the Japanese benchmark.

This comparison is particularly informative because Chinese residents may have access to more extensive co-ethnic community infrastructure than smaller foreign groups, including social networks, information channels, and greater familiarity with housing-search strategies. If such infrastructure substantially insulated respondents from perceived market disadvantage, one might expect the language channel to be weaker in this setting. Instead, Japanese proficiency remains positively associated with the perceived Japanese-applicant advantage over the Chinese applicant. Using the combined reading–speaking score, the correlation is $\rho = 0.207$ among all foreign-born respondents (p -value=0.004) and remains substantively similar within Chinese respondents themselves ($\rho = 0.201$, p -value=0.063). These results suggest that greater Japanese-language proficiency is associated with perceiving a larger Japanese-applicant advantage even when the comparison involves respondents' own nationality group and a group likely to benefit from comparatively developed co-ethnic support structures.

Taken together, these results provide suggestive support for the linguistic-asymmetry interpretation. In the aggregate comparison across non-Japanese applicants, the association is concentrated among respondents with the lowest Japanese proficiency. In the fixed Japanese–Chinese comparison, the association is positive and remains substantively similar when restricted to

²⁷We exclude the Western-Japanese applicant as foreign participants – unlike native participants – appear not to strongly differentiate between native and Western-Japanese profiles (see Figure 3).

²⁸Tokyo Metropolitan Government, *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook 2023*, Table 2-4, “Foreign Residents by District and Nationality,” available at <https://www.toukei.metro.tokyo.lg.jp/tnenkan/2023/tn23q3e002.htm>.

Chinese respondents. This pattern is consistent with the idea that Japanese-language access shapes perceptions of nationality-based disadvantage, while also indicating that the strength and form of the association depend on the comparison group considered.

4.5.5 Summary of GGDD

The classic PGDD literature has been highlighted perceptions of minority group disadvantage perceived by minority (auto-stereotype). More recently, studies have extended the analysis of perceived discrimination to majority populations. For instance, McAvay and Safi (2025) extended the study of perceived discrimination to include majority respondents. However, such studies typically examine whether respondents perceive discrimination affecting their own group, which is sometimes termed “reverse discrimination.” By contrast, the present study compares majority and minority perception of disadvantage facing the same minority group. This distinction allows us to identify a further discrepancy between auto-stereotypes and hetero-stereotypes that remains invisible in conventional PGDD designs.

The present findings suggest that such perceptions are not confined to foreign-born respondents. Across respondent groups, non-Japanese applicants were consistently evaluated as having lower probabilities of receiving a viewing invitation than otherwise identical Japanese applicants (hetero-stereotype). The existence of this expectation among native Japanese respondents is particularly noteworthy. Our analysis established that perceptions of group disadvantage are socially shared across the wider population. In other words, the expectation of unequal treatment appears to function not merely as a minority belief but as a collectively recognised feature of the housing market.

At the same time, this consensus does not extend to the perceived magnitude of disadvantage. Whereas PGDD concerns the divergence between personal and group-level perceptions, our findings reveal an additional pattern: a divergence between majority and minority perceptions of disadvantage facing the same minority group. We term this phenomenon the Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (GGDD). In shorthand, the pattern may be described as “My group is disadvantaged, but not as much as you think.” Foreign-born respondents recognise substantial disadvantages faced by their group, yet consistently assign smaller penalties than those attributed by Japanese respondents.

The existence of GGDD raises a broader question concerning the origins of group-level perceptions. Foreign-born respondents may draw partly on personal experiences of exclusion. However, native Japanese respondents do not directly experience nationality-based exclusion in the rental market, yet nevertheless perceive substantial and greater disadvantages facing non-Japanese applicants. This suggests that evaluations of disadvantages faced by foreigners may be informed by sources extending beyond direct experience. To provide some evidence for such sources accessible to everyone in Japan’s society, we turn next to data beyond our survey.

4.6 Contextual Evidence

Taylor et al. (1996) suggests the different processes governing perceptions of discrimination at the group level, which they call “the activation of shared stereotype” (198). The preceding analysis established not only auto-stereotypes of foreign group disadvantage perceived among foreign-born respondents, but also hetero-stereotypes among native Japanese respondents. More strikingly, perceptions of disadvantage were socially shared across respondent groups despite the fact that Japanese respondents do not themselves experience nationality-based exclusion in Japanese housing market. The institutional context discussed in section 2 suggests that discriminatory behaviour toward foreigners in Japan’s rental market may persist more openly than

in many other developed economies. In particular, weak anti-discrimination protections in the housing sector and limited restrictions on discriminatory public expression create conditions under which exclusionary practices may remain publicly observable. To examine whether such signals are, in fact, visible, we next turn to two complementary sources of evidence.

First, qualitative evidence from journalistic reporting highlights the continued prevalence of discriminatory treatment toward foreign residents in the housing sector. Shaun McKenna’s investigation for *The Japan Times* documents repeated cases in which foreign residents were denied housing applications solely on the basis of nationality, despite meeting standard financial and contractual requirements.²⁹ It further reports that real estate agents frequently justify these exclusions by citing landlords’ concerns about communication barriers, cultural differences, or perceived risks associated with non-Japanese tenants. Importantly, the article emphasizes that such practices persist partly because Japan lacks comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation specifically prohibiting nationality-based exclusion in the housing market. Interviews with affected residents and housing advocates suggest that discriminatory screening practices are sufficiently common to constitute a well-recognized obstacle for foreigners seeking accommodation in major urban areas.

Second, we provide quantitative evidence by a visibility-based method examining how references to foreign tenants appear in publicly discoverable search across major Japanese real estate platforms: SUUMO, LIFULL HOME’S, and at home.³⁰ During our observation window between May 22–24, 2026, the three platforms jointly hosted more than 14.8 million listings, with SUUMO being the largest platform (approximately 7.56 million listings), followed by HOME’S (5.02 million) and at home (2.24 million). Using Google site-restricted searches conducted from a UK IP address, we searched the free-text content of listings for multiple Japanese-language terms associated with the explicit exclusion, consideration or explicit inclusion of foreign applicants, including 外国籍不可 (“foreign nationals not allowed”), 外国人不可 (“foreigners not allowed”), 外国籍相談 (“foreign nationals negotiable”), 外国人相談 (“foreigners negotiable”), 外国籍可 (“foreign nationals allowed”), 外国人可 (“foreigners allowed”), 外国籍歓迎 (“foreign nationals welcome”), and 外国人歓迎 (“foreigners welcome”), both nationwide and for the Greater Tokyo area.

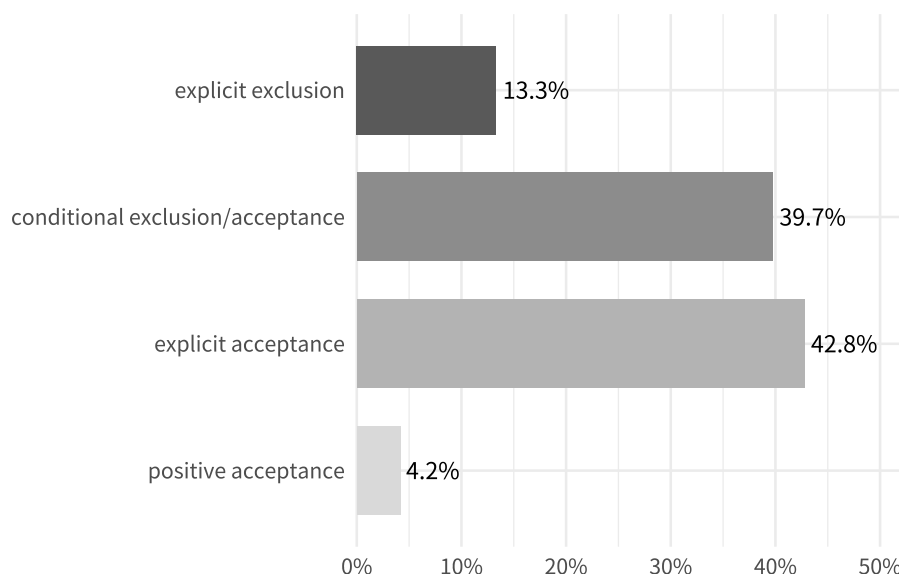
Among those adverts that do contain such references, we can therefore assess the relative prevalence of exclusionary, conditional, and explicitly inclusive language. Results shown in Figure 5 indicate that the use of explicit exclusionary language remains widespread. In our sample, 13.3% of nationality-related search results in our visibility exercise across the three platforms contained clearly exclusionary wording, suggesting that such practices are not isolated incidents but rather a commonly observable feature of the housing market. An additional 39.7% of advertisements were only conditionally willing to accept foreigners, whereas 46.9% were unconditionally open to foreign tenants.

While the vast majority of adverts do not contain any of these nationality-related terms, explicit references to foreign applicants do exist and, importantly, such statements are not prohibited in Japan (see subsection 2.3). This contrasts with a number of other developed economies where equality legislation prohibit nationality-based screening in property advertisements, as discussed in the previous section. In some jurisdictions, protection extends beyond race, nationality and other traditional protected grounds. For example, following a successful proceedings brought

²⁹Shaun McKenna, “What’s Behind Housing Discrimination in Japan?,” *The Japan Times*, May 31, 2021, <https://www.japantimes.co.jp/community/2021/05/31/how-tos/housing-discrimination-still-problem-japan/>.

³⁰SUUMO: <https://suumo.jp>; HOME’S: <https://www.homes.co.jp>; at home: <https://www.athome.co.jp>.

Figure 5: Distribution of Nationality-Related Rental Listing Search Results



Notes: The Figure aggregates search terms cross platforms and into four categories: explicit exclusion, conditional exclusion/acceptance, explicit acceptance, and positive acceptance. Shares are calculated relative to all relevant search results returned by the platform-specific Google searches.

by the Irish Human Rights and Equality Commission in 2019, Irish rental advertisements may no longer specify preferred tenant characteristics based on family status or receipt of housing allowance.³¹ Although Ireland’s framework reflects the EU *Racial Equality Directive*, it extends protection beyond the Directive’s minimum requirements. In comparative perspectives, the nationality-based signalling within Japanese property market would be regarded as illegal discrimination or at least its strong indicator.

The significance of these findings lies not primarily in the prevalence of such advertisements, but in their visibility, which may itself be consequential. Even where such language does not necessarily reflect the intentions of other landlords, its repeated appearance within publicly accessible search results may itself contribute to perceptions of different treatment and social inclusion. Housing discrimination frequently operates through subtle and discretionary mechanisms rather than explicit exclusion. Prospective tenants may encounter non-responses, differential treatment during enquiries, additional documentary requirements, non-invitation at the viewing stage, or opaque selection decisions. In such settings, unequal treatment is often difficult to identify from individual transaction alone.

While our visibility search provides evidence that nationality-based exclusion remains present in Tokyo’s rental market, they do not reveal how such practices are perceived by market participants themselves. The visibility of nationality-related language is open to more than one interpretation. On one view, such advertisements may represent isolated expectations within an otherwise open rental market. On other, explicit acceptance language may itself indicate that differential treatment is sufficiently expected that landlords willing to rent to foreign applicants must actively signal their openness. Under this latter interpretation, references such as ‘foreign nationals negotiable’ may suggest that equal access cannot be assumed as the market baseline.

Yet, perceptions of discrimination are economically important in their own right, as anticipated

³¹See “Rental ads can no longer specify preferred tenants as IHREC wins equality case,” *Law Society Gazette*, August 2019, <https://www.lawsociety.ie/gazette/top-stories/2019/08-august/rental-ads-can-no-longer-specify-preferred-tenants-as-ihrec-wins-equality-case>.

unequal treatment may influence housing search behaviour, application strategies, housing choices and finally also broader expectations of social inclusion.

More generally, stated expectations in the present setting may capture both descriptive beliefs about how landlords and agents are likely to behave and injunctive beliefs regarding the social acceptability of exclusionary screening practices. Experimental evidence suggests that discriminatory behaviour is shaped not only by private preferences, but also by prevailing social norms concerning the appropriateness of discrimination (Barr et al., 2018). In institutional environments where anti-discrimination norms are comparatively weak or ambiguously enforced, respondents' expectations may therefore reflect both anticipated market behaviour and broader perceptions regarding which forms of exclusion are socially tolerated.

5 Discussion

5.1 Mapping the Perceptual Discrepancies

The empirical analysis yields three findings that structure the discussion. First, both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents perceive lower viewing probabilities for non-Japanese applicants than for otherwise identical Japanese applicants. This indicates that foreign disadvantage in Tokyo's rental market is not only reported by affected groups, but is also recognised by majority respondents. Second, foreign-born respondents evaluate their own chances of receiving a viewing invitation more favourably than those of their broader nationality group. This self-group gap corresponds to the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy and suggests that perceptions of personal access and collective disadvantage are shaped by partly distinct mechanisms. Third, Japanese respondents perceive larger disadvantages facing non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents themselves. This majority-minority gap motivates our concept of Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy, which captures differences in how majority and minority respondents assess disadvantage facing the same minority group. The discussion therefore proceeds by interpreting these three empirical patterns in turn and by linking them to the institutional and informational context of Tokyo's rental housing market.

The relationships between the perceptual discrepancies identified in this study may be summarised as follows:

$$\text{Hetero-stereotype} \overset{\text{GGDD}}{>} \text{Auto-stereotype} \overset{\text{PGDD}}{>} \text{Personal disadvantage.}$$

The discrepancy between auto-stereotypes and perceived personal disadvantage corresponds to the classic Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (PGDD), while the discrepancy between hetero-stereotypes and auto-stereotypes is what we term the GGDD. The existence of both PGDD and GGDD is particularly difficult to explain through personal experience alone.

This gives rise to a question: What explains the progressive diminish of perceived disadvantage from hetero-stereotype, through auto-stereotype, to personal disadvantage? To answer this, we use Japanese respondents' evaluations as a provisional interpretive benchmark. As members of the majority group, Japanese respondents may be comparatively well positioned to recognise the stigma attached to non-Japanese identity and its implications in the rental market. Therefore, their evaluations provide a useful reference point for examining why foreign-born respondents perceive less disadvantage at both the group and personal level. We argue that this pattern of progressive attenuation reflects the combination of epistemic burden and minority adaptation, while their relative importance differs across the two perceptual gaps.

5.2 Interpreting the Group-Group Discrimination Discrepancy

Taking the hetero-stereotype as a provisional interpretive reference point, GGDD suggests that minority respondents underestimate the gap between minority-side penalty and majority-side premium.

The literature on PGDD emphasises collective experience in the perception of group-level disadvantage (McAvay and Safi (2025); Taylor et al. (1996)). Such collective representations of disadvantage may be acquired through media exposure, public discourse, and awareness of discriminatory incidents affecting other group members. The Tokyo context provides several mechanisms through which such collective perceptions may emerge. As documented in subsection 4.6, publicly accessible rental advertisements continue to contain explicit exclusionary language, conditional acceptance criteria, and nationality-related screening signals.

The hypothesis regarding the formation of group-level perceptions through collectively available information is consistent with our education finding. Across both Japanese and foreign-born respondents, higher level of educational attainment are associated with stronger perceptions of disadvantage facing non-Japanese applicants. Higher educational attainment may increase individuals' exposure to information concerning collective disadvantage through media, public discourse, and broader social knowledge, which strengthen perceptions of group-level disadvantage.

The disparity between the collective representation held by majority and minority respondents may, in turn, be explained partly by the asymmetric epistemic burden they face. Among foreign-born respondents, the relationship between Japanese-language proficiency and perceived disadvantage displays a threshold effect. That is, those with the lowest proficiency perceive a substantially smaller gap between Japanese and non-Japanese applicants than respondents above that threshold.

Japanese respondents may be exposed to a broader range of Japanese-language discussions, including media coverage, public discourse, and exclusionary listing language. Unlike countries where public discourse is routinely available in multiple languages, Japan's low level of English proficiency limits the extent to which Japanese-language public discourse is reproduced or conducted in English.³² Japan's public sphere remains overwhelmingly Japanese-language. Public discussion concerning immigration, housing access, discriminatory incidents, and nationality-based screening therefore occurs primarily in Japanese. Likewise, as discussed in subsection 4.6, nationality-related exclusion remains visible in Japanese-language rental advertisements. Consequently, such signals may be more readily observable to native Japanese respondents even without direct experience of the rental application process.

This linguistic asymmetry may allow Japanese respondents to recognise the stigma attached to non-Japanese identity even without personally experiencing exclusion. Conversely, foreign-born residents bear a greater epistemic burden when forming group-level assessments. This may help explain the attenuation of auto-stereotype, in comparison to hetero-stereotype in Japanese rental market.

5.3 Interpreting the Personal-Group Discrimination Discrepancy (PGDD)

While GGDD involves under-recognition of an existing distance between minority and majority groups, PGDD involves the preception of a distance between oneself and one's own group. PGDD may arise through two complementary mechanisms.

³²The EF English Proficiency Index 2025 edition classifies Japan as "Very low proficiency," ranked 97th out of 123 countries. EF English Proficiency Index, 2025 edition. Accessible at <https://www.ef.com/wwen/epi/>.

First, in evaluating self-disadvantage, individuals often bear greater epistemic burden. Discrimination is harder to attribute to a concrete action than abstract group disadvantage, especially where the outcome appears to allow several plausible explanations. This attributional difficulty is particularly acute in rental housing contexts. An ordinary rejection, including non-response, failure to receive an invitation to viewing, or rejection ostensibly based on some other reason, makes the explanations of such an action epistemically indeterminate. Membership in a minority group is only individual's identity. As a result, an individual may recognise their group discrimination more easily than ascribe it treatment.

Second, minority individuals may adopt both psychological and behavioural coping mechanism, which contributes to underevaluation of self-disadvantage.

A second adaptation-based explanation emphasises behavioural rather than psychological responses to perceived discrimination, which may lead individuals to discount personal disadvantage. Such individuals may say "I know foreigners face barriers, but I also know the workarounds." Individuals who anticipate market barriers may gradually adopt strategies and social networks that allow them to navigate those barriers more effectively. As a result, they may recognise substantial group disadvantages in general while simultaneously believing that they themselves are capable of securing accommodation through accumulated experience, local knowledge, or informal support networks.

In our study, higher-income respondents reported more optimistic expectations regarding their own ability to secure accommodation. This pattern is consistent with the view that respondents evaluate not only the existence of general market barriers but also their own capacity to navigate them. Individuals possessing greater economic resources may reasonably perceive themselves as better equipped to overcome constraints. However, even though such adaptation is individually rational, whether it is economically optimal from a broader societal perspective is a different question.

Under this interpretation, PGDD does not arise because individuals deny the existence of discrimination. Rather, it reflects behavioural responses to perceived disadvantage. This distinction between psychological and behavioural adaptation is important because behavioural adaptation has implications extending individual beliefs, potentially generating economically consequential effects at the societal level.

5.4 Policy Implications for Anti-Discrimination Regulations

Japan has adopted neither comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation nor an explicit statutory prohibition of discrimination in the housing sector. Nationality-based housing discrimination is instead addressed largely on a case-by-case basis through general private-law claims initiated by affected individuals. Our findings of PGDD and GGDD in Tokyo's rental market expose structural weaknesses in two pathways for correcting discrimination, namely, judicial correction through individual claims and democratic correction through collective political action. PGDD weakens the former, while GGDD may weaken the latter.

First, PGDD indicates that individuals may recognise disadvantage facing their minority group without identifying themselves as personally disadvantaged. In housing, this discrepancy is further aggravated by the epistemic burden involved in attributing an adverse outcome to discrimination where several explanations remain possible. This under-recognition of personal disadvantage leads to under-litigation. Under-recognition of personal discrimination may thus lead to underreporting and under-litigation.

Even when an individual brings proceedings, the same epistemic burden becomes an evidential burden (burden of proof), which requires litigants to prove causal connection between

discrimination and the particular outcome. Limited disclosure and demanding standard of proof in Japanese civil litigation may thus produce judicial under-enforcement. Comprehensive anti-discrimination legislation could perform an important educational and expressive function, which could mitigate the issue of under-reporting to a certain extent. However, legislation alone would not eliminate the issue if enforcement require individual claimants strict causal attribution for opaque decisions.

Second, GGDD in our study suggests that minority members may underestimate the magnitude of disadvantage facing their group. By reducing the perceived scale and commonality of that disadvantage, GGDD may also reduce the perceived benefit of cooperation and the apparent urgency of systemic reform. As a result, it may create a structural obstacle to cooperation and collective political action, on which democratic correction system relies.

In principle, the economic inefficiencies produced by discrimination could motivate majority politicians to support anti-discrimination measures even in the absence of strong pressure from affected minorities. However, as discussed in Section 2, Japan relies economically on foreign labour while continuing to frame foreign residents principally as workers rather than as immigrants and members of the political community. The benefits of anti-discrimination protection may consequently produce only limited electoral rewards, in comparison to its perceived political costs. The restricted political incorporation of foreign residents and the underestimation of collective disadvantage identified by GGDD may thus reinforce one another, weakening democratic demand for systemic reform.

Finally, while the systematic underestimation of self-disadvantage in PGDD may mitigate dignity and distributive harm that discrimination inflicts, nationality-based screening creates market-access friction. As suggested by our visibility-based inquiry in \autoref{sec:objective}, foreign applicants may rely disproportionately on agencies, landlords or housing channels that explicitly signal a willingness to accommodate foreign tenants. Foreign residents may therefore adapt by directing their searches towards providers known to be receptive to foreign applicants. Such targeted searching can reduce individual search costs and increase the probability of securing accommodation. Personal experience may consequently be more favourable than the opportunities perceived to be available to the broader group: respondents may recognise substantial barriers facing non-Japanese residents while believing that accumulated experience, local knowledge, language skills or targeted search strategies enable them to navigate those barriers successfully.

Although individually rational, this form of adaptation may not eliminate the underlying market friction. Instead, it may contribute to market segmentation, with foreign and Japanese applicants searching through partly separate networks of landlords, agencies and listings. Segmentation reduces the pool of potential matches available to both tenants and housing providers, weakens competition across market segments and may allow differences in price, quality and location to persist. It may also insulate less receptive housing providers from competitive pressure to change their practices, because foreign applicants learn to avoid them rather than challenge or enter that part of the market.

Accordingly, minority respondents' relatively favourable assessments of their personal prospects do not necessarily indicate that nationality-based barriers have become economically insignificant. Successful access through specialised channels may coexist with the continued inaccessibility of a substantial part of the mainstream rental market. The resulting misallocation may extend beyond housing: constrained residential choice can affect access to employment, education, transport and social networks. Minority adaptation may therefore mitigate the private costs of discrimination for particular individuals while leaving—and potentially reinforcing—the wider market inefficiency created by nationality-based screening.

6 Conclusions

This study examines perceived ethnic discrimination in Tokyo’s rental housing market using a survey experiment. Both native Japanese and foreign-born respondents expect applicants with non-Japanese names to face substantially lower chances of receiving a viewing invitation than an otherwise identical Japanese applicant. These findings suggest that unequal treatment in rental access is not only perceived by minority groups themselves, but is also widely recognised by the majority population.

The paper makes three main contributions. First, it provides new evidence on perceived discrimination in a non-Western housing market during a period of demographic, legal, and institutional change in Japan, where growing reliance on foreign labour coexists with weak explicit protections against discrimination in private rental markets. Second, by focusing on subjective expectations rather than realised outcomes, it complements the large correspondence-study literature and highlights how perceptions themselves may shape housing-search behaviour and market participation. Third, the paper contributes to the limited literature on PGDD in housing contexts by showing that respondents systematically assess their own prospects more favourably than those of their broader nationality group.

Several additional findings emerge from the analysis. Native Japanese respondents perceive larger penalties for non-Japanese applicants than foreign-born respondents, although both groups rank applicants similarly overall. Perceived disadvantage also varies systematically across ethnic categories, with Western-Japanese applicants viewed as substantially closer to native Japanese applicants than other non-Japanese groups. In addition, perceptions differ across respondents’ socio-economic characteristics: older, higher-income, and university-educated respondents perceive larger disadvantages for non-Japanese applicants, whereas gender differences are limited.

Among foreign-born respondents, prior experiences of everyday discrimination are strongly associated with more pessimistic expectations regarding rental access. By contrast, conventional indicators of integration—such as visa status and length of stay—show comparatively limited explanatory power. These findings suggest that subjective experiences and broader perceptions of social treatment may shape expectations in the housing market more strongly than formal indicators of integration alone.

The PGDD finding also provides insight into how perceptions of discrimination may be formed and maintained. Consistent with the framework proposed by Taylor et al. (1996), the discrepancy between personal and group-level evaluations suggests that perceptions of housing access operate simultaneously at individual and collective levels. Foreign-born respondents may evaluate their own prospects more favourably because they adapt their search behaviour, acquire local knowledge, or successfully access segments of the market that are more receptive to foreign tenants. At the same time, perceptions of disadvantage directed at the broader group may be reinforced through publicly visible exclusionary signals, media reporting, and awareness of discriminatory experiences affecting other foreign residents. Importantly, the expectation that non-Japanese applicants face lower chances of receiving a viewing invitation was shared not only by foreign-born respondents but also by native Japanese respondents. This suggests that perceptions of unequal access have become socially shared understandings of the housing market rather than merely reflections of individual experience.

Overall, the results highlight a gap between formal access to housing and perceived access to housing in contemporary Japan. This gap is particularly important in light of Japan’s legal and institutional framework. Although nationality-based exclusion in housing has, in some cases, been recognised as unlawful through general civil-law principles, Japan lacks explicit

statutory housing anti-discrimination provisions and an independent equality body with binding enforcement powers. The findings therefore suggest that perceived discrimination is not only a matter of individual expectations or isolated landlord behaviour, but also of socially shared beliefs regarding who is likely to gain access to housing and who is perceived as belonging within the market. More broadly, the results resonate with scholarship on East Asian migration regimes arguing that foreign labour is frequently incorporated through systems of conditional and temporary belonging rather than full social membership (Bell and Piper, 2005).

As Japan’s foreign-born population continues to grow, reducing both perceived and actual barriers in rental markets may require more than case-by-case remedies. Greater transparency in tenant-screening processes, clearer legal standards for real-estate agents and landlords, and institutional mechanisms that signal equal access to housing as a binding norm may be necessary to make non-discriminatory rental access credible in practice. In this sense, housing anti-discrimination law may matter not only by deterring unlawful conduct, but also through its expressive function: by shaping whether exclusionary screening is perceived as socially and institutionally tolerated.

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Appendix

A Historical Development of Tokyo's Rental Housing Market

This appendix provides additional historical and institutional background on the development of Tokyo's rental housing market.

A.1 Spatial Order under Tokugawa Japan and the Development of Rental Housing

The feudal order of Tokugawa Japan (1603–1868) had a lasting influence on Edo's urban structure and, by extension, on the development of what is now Tokyo's rental housing market. Edo was organised around the political authority of the Tokugawa shogunate and the spatial hierarchy of samurai and daimyo households. Daimyo were themselves differentiated into hierarchical categories, including *shimpan*, *fudai*, and *tozama*, with politically trusted groups located closer to the centre of power.

This spatial and political hierarchy reflected broader insider–outsider distinctions within Tokugawa society. These distinctions were embedded in household-based forms of social organisation and dependency, in which tenants, servants, and retainers could be incorporated into quasi-familial structures, while those outside such networks were positioned as social outsiders. Historical accounts suggest that this distinction continued to shape modern perceptions of non-Japanese residents as socially separate outsiders.

The concentration of daimyo and samurai households in Edo also contributed to the development of rental arrangements. Samurai land was not freely alienable in the same way as commercially transferable urban land in cities such as Osaka. As a result, financially constrained samurai households increasingly rented out land rather than transferring ownership. This practice later spread beyond samurai districts and contributed to the historically high prevalence of rental housing in Tokyo.

Following the Meiji Restoration and the Land Tax Reform, land became increasingly commodified and subject to taxation. These institutional changes further incentivised landlords to generate income through leasing while retaining ownership. At the same time, landownership continued to carry symbolic and status-related significance, particularly in former samurai districts. These historical developments contributed to the long-standing importance of rental housing in Tokyo.

A.2 Wartime Tenant Protection and Long-Term Tenure Security

The introduction of the *Building Protection Act*, the *Land Lease Act*, and the *Building Lease Act* before and after WWI was driven by rapid land price inflation, which incentivised landlords to transfer land to third-party to remove tenants whose leasehold interests lacked proprietary protection under Japanese civil law.

However, the decisive transformation of Japanese tenant protection occurred during the transition toward a total-war economy, following the Second Sino-Japanese War beginning in 1937. Against the background of wartime militarism, the government sought to stabilise urban labour supply for armament production and the war economy. Under the National Mobilisation Law (1938), the government introduced the *Rent Control Order* in October 1939, shortly after the wartime rent control in the United Kingdom in September 1939 and Germany's nationwide rent freeze in 1936. The 1939 Order froze the rent *ex post* at the August 1938 level, which may be categorised as a first-generation rent control due to its rigidity under Arnott (1995)'s distinction between 'first-generation' and 'second-generation' rent control regimes, although Arnott's

analysis primarily concerns North American and European housing markets. Shortly before the Pearl Harbor attack, the 1941 amendments to the *Land Lease Act* and the *Building Lease Act* sought to give practical effect to wartime rent control by preventing landlords from circumventing rent restrictions through eviction threats and demands for illegal surcharges. The amendments maximised tenure security by introducing automatic renewal mechanisms and the 'just cause' requirement, severely restricting landlords' ability to refuse renewal or terminate leases.

Japan was therefore not an outlier but part of a broader international pattern: many countries introduced or strengthened rent-control and tenant-protection measures in response to war-related inflation, soaring rents, housing shortages, and still-limited general tenant protections (Kholodilin, 2024; Kholodilin et al., 2021). In Japan, however, wartime tenant-protection mechanisms did not remain merely temporary emergency measures. As the March 1945 fire-bombing significantly reduced Tokyo's housing stock, owing to the combination of densely built urban neighbourhoods and highly flammable wooden housing, the wartime tenant-protection regimes survived the end of the war, as occurred in several European jurisdictions. The post-war *Act on Land and Building Lease* largely inherited the framework established through the wartime amendments, particularly the strong renewal protections and the 'just cause' requirement. This legal framework contributed to the widely recognised landlord perception that 'once leased out, never comes back.' This institutional structure has contributed to persistent risk-averse behaviour among landlords in the Japanese rental housing market.

A.3 Postwar and Post-Bubble Developments

The postwar rental housing system continued to be shaped by strong tenant protections and long-term rental reliance. Although the 2000 amendment introduced fixed-term building leases as an alternative to ordinary leases, the fixed-term system remained relatively uncommon for more than two decades. Ordinary leases, to which automatic renewal and the "just cause" requirement continue to apply, remained the dominant framework.

The prolonged decline in land prices following the burst of Japan's asset-price bubble in the early 1990s further reinforced the relative stability of rental tenancies. During this period, landlords had limited incentives to terminate existing leases for redevelopment or rent increases. At the same time, concerns over negative equity, mortgage availability, and the relatively short economic lifespan of many Japanese housing structures contributed to continued reliance on rental housing among younger and more mobile households.

In this institutional context, Tokyo's rental market differs from housing systems in which renting is primarily treated as a short transitional stage before homeownership. Instead, rental housing constitutes a central and often long-term tenure form. This makes access to rental housing particularly important for social and economic integration, especially for foreign-born residents whose housing opportunities are mediated through private landlords and real-estate agents.

B Survey Administration and Data Quality Procedures

This appendix provides additional details on the implementation of the survey and the data-quality procedures used to construct the final analysis sample.

The survey was administered online between April and May 2025 using the Japanese panel provider *GMO Research*. The target sample consisted of approximately 800 Japanese nationals and 200 foreign-born residents living in the Greater Tokyo area. Foreign-born respondents were oversampled to ensure sufficient statistical power for subgroup analyses. The questionnaire was implemented in Qualtrics and included several quality-control procedures. These included

minimum completion-time thresholds, response-completeness checks, location validation, and duplicate-response prevention.

Observations were excluded where respondents failed these checks or provided incomplete or internally inconsistent responses.

Ethical approval was obtained from the Department of Land Economy in April 2025, and all participants provided informed consent prior to participation.

C Construction and Validation of Applicant Names

C.1 Selection of Applicant Profiles

Applicant profiles were constructed using *Japanese Immigration Agency* (2024) data to reflect the composition of the 30.7% increase in migrants between 2018 and 2025. The selected profiles correspond to the principal nationality and visa groups represented in Tokyo’s foreign resident population. In addition to foreign-born applicant groups, two benchmark profiles were included: a native Japanese applicant and a Western-Japanese applicant (i.e., a foreign-born individual of partial Japanese descent). The latter group was included because prior research suggests that co-ethnicity and perceived cultural proximity may shape evaluations of migrants in Japan (Shipper, 2016).

All applicant characteristics other than names were held constant across profiles in order to isolate perceptions associated with ethnic signals conveyed through names. Applicant identities were standardised as male to reflect prevailing market norms and minimise gender-related variation. This approach is supported by evidence indicating that males may face greater discrimination in rental markets, thereby reducing the need for gender-based stratification (Ahmed and Hammarstedt, 2008; Huang and Bao, 2026). Gender-ambiguous names were avoided to ensure clarity.

C.2 Name Validation Procedure

To ensure that applicant names were recognisable and consistently associated with the intended ethnic categories, a bilingual pre-test was conducted using a sample of 100 respondents recruited through *Prolific*, supplemented by targeted recruitment of Japanese participants.

Respondents were asked to identify the likely ethnic background associated with each name. Names were retained only if they achieved a recognition accuracy threshold of at least 70%, consistent with conventions in correspondence-study research (e.g., Ahmed and Hammarstedt, 2008). Names failing to meet this threshold were excluded from the final survey instrument.

Mean recognisability was higher in English-language responses (94%) than in Japanese-language responses (83%), reflecting linguistic constraints associated with transliteration into Japanese script. While ANOVA results showed no statistically significant differences across names, the model explained more than 60% of the variation in recognition outcomes, indicating meaningful differentiation between applicant categories.

The name validation exercise additionally served as a pilot test for the broader experimental design by assessing whether ethnic signals embedded in names remained sufficiently salient once presented in Japanese script.

C.3 Script Standardisation and Linguistic Design

A key methodological consideration was whether names would remain ethnically distinguishable once translated into Japanese script. To preserve ethnic salience while maintaining comparability across profiles, non-Japanese names were standardised using Katakana characters, which are conventionally used in Japanese for foreign names and loan words. Distinctly Japanese names were presented in Kanji characters. For Western–Japanese profiles, first names were rendered in Katakana and surnames in Kanji to preserve cultural plausibility and reflect mixed ethnic identity.

This approach standardised the presentation of applicant names while enhancing the perceptual salience of ethnic categories that were not Japanese. Prior studies emphasise that Katakana script itself conveys social and ethnic meaning in Japanese contexts (Hanai, 2016). However, loan words written in Katakana do not automatically trigger a specific ethnic association unless supported by cultural familiarity or media exposure (Tamaoka and Miyaoka, 2003). Consequently, respondents’ perceptions of names are shaped not only by phonetic structure but also by broader social experience, making Katakana particularly appropriate for studying implicit bias and perceived foreignness.

Particular care was also taken to avoid pronunciation or character ambiguities across East Asian languages. For example, the Chinese surname character 張, commonly pronounced “Zhang” in Mandarin, is pronounced “Chō” in Japanese contexts. To avoid such ambiguities, native Chinese characters were not used directly in the applicant profiles. Instead, names were transliterated into Katakana to ensure that respondents interpreted ethnic signals consistently across profiles.

The final applicant profiles and their corresponding renderings in native script and Katakana are presented in Table 1.

C.4 Translation Procedures

The survey was originally developed in English and translated into Japanese using machine translation, followed by verification by four native speakers. Additional language versions were subsequently developed for Indonesian, Simplified Chinese, English, Hindi, Korean, Burmese, Nepali, Portuguese, and Vietnamese, reflecting the language categories used in the Ministry of Justice Basic Foreign Residents’ Survey and covering the largest foreign resident groups in Japan.

The multilingual implementation was designed to maximise accessibility among foreign-born residents while minimising interpretation bias across respondent groups. Japanese was set as the default language option. Active switching to an alternative language version was interpreted as an indicator of lower cultural assimilation and incorporated into the broader analysis of integration-related characteristics.

D Supplemental Questions for Non-Native Japanese Speakers

D.1 Japanese Language Ability

Speaking Ability

Question: How well can you carry a conversation in Japanese?

1. I can carry on a conversation appropriately with anyone, in any situation, on any subject.

2. I can converse fluently and naturally.
3. I can converse as needed in everyday life.
4. I can exchange basic information about family matters.
5. I can use frequently-used greetings and everyday phrases.
6. I cannot carry on a conversation at all.

Reading Ability

Question: How well can you read Japanese?

1. I can read any written material with ease.
2. I can read newspaper articles that are written from certain perspectives.
3. I can read emails that are written using everyday words and phrases.
4. I can read short and easy writings about familiar matters.
5. I can read familiar names and words used in signs and posters.
6. I cannot read well at all.

D.2 Everyday Discrimination Scale (EDS)

Question: In your day-to-day life, how often do any of the following things happen to you?

a) Situations

1. You are treated with less courtesy than other people.
2. You receive poorer service than other people at restaurants or stores.
3. People act as if they are afraid of you.
4. People act as if they think that you are dishonest.

b) Response Scale

- Almost every day
- At least once a week
- A few times a month
- A few times a year
- Less than once a year
- Never

E Supplemental Analyses

E.1 Language Proficiency and Perceived Japanese-Applicant Advantage

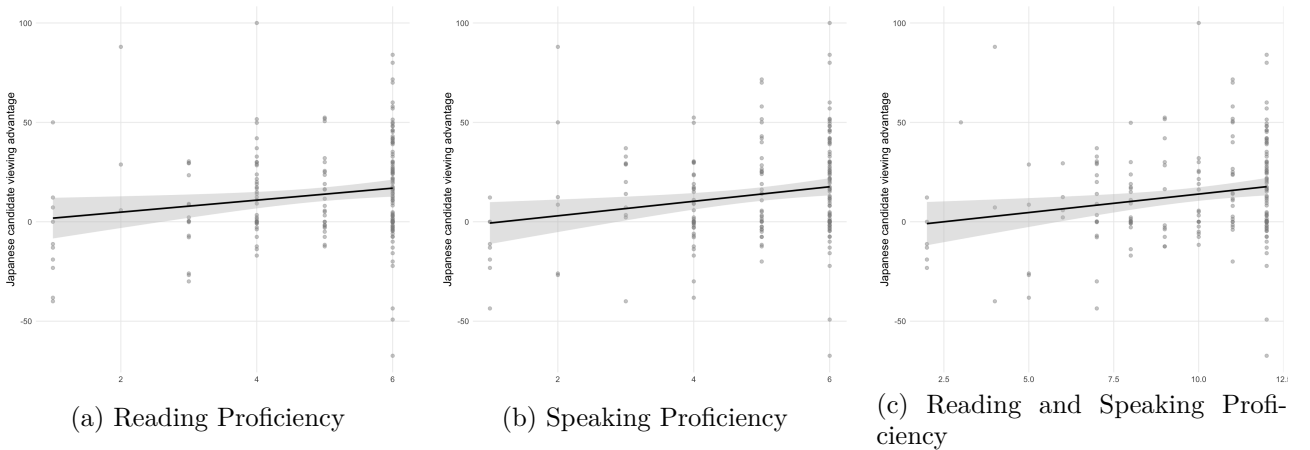
This appendix reports auxiliary analyses examining whether Japanese-language proficiency among foreign-born respondents is associated with perceived relative advantage for the Japanese applicant, complementing results reported in ???. These analyses should be interpreted as suggestive mechanism evidence rather than as direct estimates of GGDD. GGDD refers to differences between majority- and minority-group assessments of the disadvantage facing the same minority group. By contrast, the tests below examine heterogeneity among foreign-born respondents by asking whether respondents with greater Japanese-language proficiency perceive a larger advantage for the Japanese applicant relative to foreign comparison applicants.

The empirical logic is as follows. If Japanese-language access shapes exposure to housing-market information, then foreign-born respondents with greater Japanese proficiency may be more likely to observe Japanese-language rental advertisements, agent communication, public discussion of exclusionary screening, and informal knowledge about search frictions faced by foreign applicants. This may lead them to perceive a larger Japanese-applicant advantage. We examine this possibility using two complementary outcomes.

The first outcome is the gap between the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant and the average stated viewing likelihood of non-Japanese comparison applicants, excluding the respondent's own profile type and the Western-Japanese profile. Larger values indicate a larger perceived Japanese-applicant advantage. The respondent's own profile type is excluded because it partly captures personal evaluation rather than group-level perception. The Western-Japanese profile is excluded because the main results show that respondents evaluate this profile differently from other non-Japanese profiles, consistent with its partial insider status.

Visual inspection of Figure 6 suggests a threshold pattern: respondents with minimal Japanese proficiency perceive little or no Japanese-applicant advantage, whereas differences among respondents above this lowest-proficiency group appear comparatively small.

Figure 6: Japanese-Language Proficiency and Perceived Japanese-Applicant Advantage



Notes: The outcome is the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant minus the average stated viewing likelihood of non-Japanese comparison applicants. Larger values indicate a larger perceived Japanese-applicant advantage. Points show individual foreign-born respondents. Lines show linear fits with 95 percent confidence intervals.

Therefore, rather than assuming a linear relationship, we test whether the graphical pattern is

driven by respondents at the lowest level of Japanese proficiency. For each proficiency measure, we compare respondents in the lowest observed category to all other respondents, test whether a categorical specification fits better than a linear specification, and re-estimate the correlation after excluding the lowest category.

Table 10: Lowest Japanese-Proficiency Bracket versus All Other Brackets

<i>A. Lowest proficiency bracket versus all other brackets</i>					
	Lowest bracket (N)	Mean advantage		Difference	p -value
		All other	Lowest	Lowest – others	
Reading	11	14.89	-7.52	-22.41***	0.005
Speaking	8	14.85	-12.23	-27.07***	0.002
Reading + speaking	6	14.47	-9.03	-23.50**	0.021

<i>B. Fixed Japanese–Chinese applicant gap</i>				
	All foreign-born respondents		Chinese respondents only	
	Correlation(ρ)	p -value	Correlation (ρ)	p -value
Reading	0.180**	0.011	0.220**	0.041
Speaking	0.211***	0.003	0.155	0.151
Reading + speaking	0.207***	0.004	0.201*	0.063

Note: The table compares respondents in the lowest observed Japanese-proficiency bracket with respondents in all higher proficiency brackets. The dependent variable is the Japanese-applicant viewing advantage, defined as the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant minus the average stated viewing likelihood of non-Japanese comparison applicants, excluding the self-assessment and the Western-Japanese applicant. The difference column reports the estimated difference between the lowest proficiency bracket and all other brackets, calculated as lowest bracket minus all other brackets. Panel B reports Pearson correlation coefficients between Japanese-language proficiency and the fixed Japanese–Chinese applicant gap, defined as the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant minus the stated viewing likelihood of the Chinese applicant. Larger values indicate a larger perceived advantage for the Japanese applicant. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Results reported in Panel A of Table 10 indicate that the association is concentrated among respondents with minimal Japanese proficiency. Respondents in the lowest reading category report a Japanese-applicant advantage that is 22.41 percentage points lower than that of all other foreign-born respondents ($p = 0.005$). The corresponding differences are 27.07 percentage points for speaking proficiency ($p = 0.002$) and 23.50 percentage points for the combined reading-speaking score ($p = 0.021$).

Consistent with this threshold interpretation, treating reading proficiency as a categorical variable fits significantly better than a linear specification ($p = 0.039$). The analogous categorical tests are not statistically significant for speaking ($p = 0.162$) or for the combined proficiency score ($p = 0.274$). After excluding the lowest-proficiency category, the remaining correlations are small and statistically insignificant for reading ($\rho = 0.059$, $p = .423$) and speaking ($\rho = 0.091$, $p = 0.214$), and only marginal for the combined score ($\rho = 0.131$, $p = 0.070$). Overall, the auxiliary evidence suggests a threshold pattern at the very lowest levels of Japanese proficiency rather than a general linear association across the full proficiency scale.

The second outcome is a fixed Japanese–Chinese comparison, defined as the stated viewing likelihood of the Japanese applicant minus the stated viewing likelihood of the Chinese applicant. This comparison complements the aggregate gap in two ways. First, it provides a cleaner com-

parison because the non-Japanese reference applicant is held constant, avoiding changes in the outcome that may arise from averaging across heterogeneous foreign applicant profiles. Second, it is substantively important. Chinese-origin respondents constitute the largest group among foreign-born participants in our sample, accounting for 44.8% of foreign-born respondents. Chinese nationals also represent 38.0% of Tokyo’s registered foreign population, making them the largest foreign nationality group in the city.³³ Moreover, Chinese nationals form the largest group of foreign new arrivals in the migration data used to construct the applicant profiles. For Chinese respondents, the Japanese–Chinese comparison therefore captures an own-group evaluation relative to the Japanese benchmark.

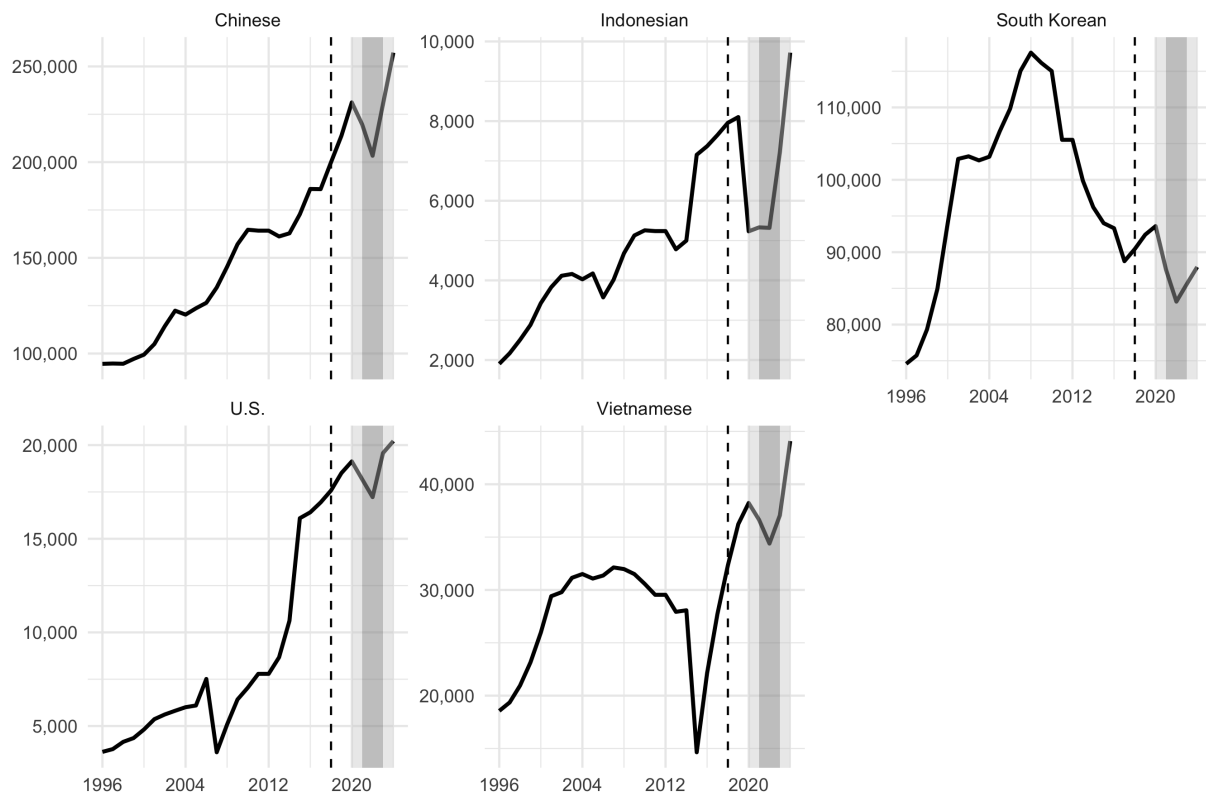
The fixed Japanese–Chinese comparison provides complementary evidence. Among all foreign-born respondents, Japanese-language proficiency is positively associated with the perceived Japanese-applicant advantage over the Chinese applicant. The correlations are positive for reading ($\rho = 0.180$, $p = 0.011$), speaking ($\rho = 0.211$, $p = 0.003$), and the combined reading-speaking score ($\rho = 0.207$, $p = 0.004$). Restricting the sample to Chinese respondents yields substantively similar estimates: $\rho = 0.220$ for reading ($p = 0.041$), $\rho = 0.155$ for speaking ($p = 0.151$), and $\rho = 0.201$ for the combined score ($p = 0.063$). These estimates suggest that Japanese-language proficiency is associated with perceiving a larger Japanese-applicant advantage even when respondents evaluate the Japanese applicant relative to the applicant representing their own nationality group.

These auxiliary results support the interpretation advanced in ???. In the aggregate comparison across non-Japanese applicants, the association is concentrated among respondents with the lowest Japanese proficiency. In the fixed Japanese–Chinese comparison, the association is positive across proficiency measures and remains substantively similar when restricted to Chinese respondents. This pattern strengthens the linguistic-asymmetry interpretation: even when the comparison holds the non-Japanese reference group constant, and even when the analysis is restricted to Chinese respondents, who belong to a large immigrant group likely to have comparatively developed co-ethnic networks and information channels, the substantive association remains similar.

F Additional Figures and Tables

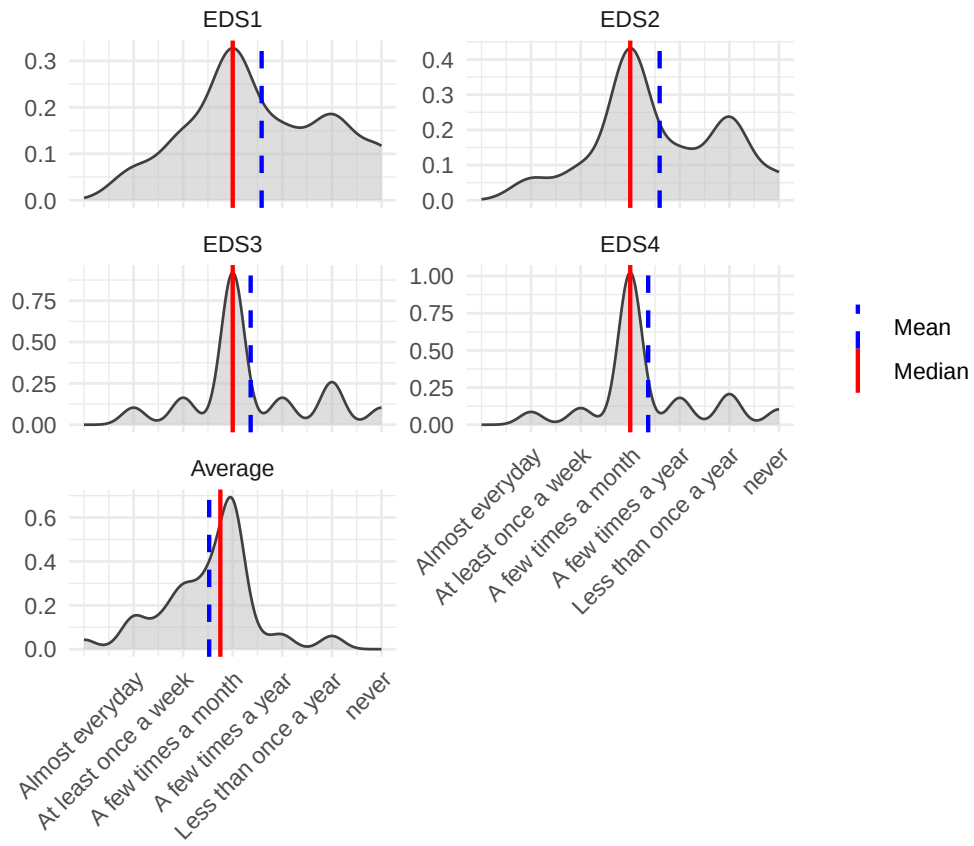
³³Tokyo Metropolitan Government, *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook 2023*, Table 2-4, “Foreign Residents by District and Nationality,” available at <https://www.toukei.metro.tokyo.lg.jp/tnenkan/2023/tn23q3e002.htm>.

Figure 7: Major Nationality Groups among Foreign Residents in Tokyo



Notes: The dashed vertical line marks the 2018 Immigration Control and Refugee Recognition Act reform. Shaded areas indicate the COVID-19 period. The darker shaded region corresponds to years fully affected by pandemic-related restrictions, while lighter shaded regions correspond to partially affected years. Data are from the *Tokyo Statistical Yearbook*.

Figure 8: EDS responses



Notes: The Figure shows densities of each EDS question as well as the density of the composite index achieved as an average across responses.

Table 11: Top Five Visa Groups in Japan

Visa Status	Representative Nationality	Population	Characteristics
Highly Skilled Professional	China (Europe second)	17,912	High skill, high income, high language proficiency
Specified Skilled Worker	Indonesia	44,305	Lower skill, lower income, low language proficiency
Technical Training Intern	Vietnam	44,305	Lower skill, lower income
Permanent Resident	China	336,086	Higher skill, high language proficiency
Special Permanent Resident	South Korea	250,881	Cultural ties, high integration

Note: Data obtained from the Japanese Immigration Agency (2024).

Table 12: Summary Statistics

Variable	Mean / Share (%)	P25	Median	P75	SD
<i>All respondents</i>					
Age	48.10	39.00	50.00	57.00	12.60
Income (brackets)	6.05	2.00	6.00	9.00	3.99
Japanese	80.50%				
Female	40.60%				
Owner-occupier	52.80%				
Degree	58.00%				
Full-time employed	47.20%				
<i>Non-Japanese residents</i>					
Age	45.10	36.00	45.00	53.00	13.40
Income (brackets)	6.48	3.00	7.00	10.00	4.01
Female	51.20%				
Owner-occupier	52.70%				
Degree	70.90%				
Full-time employed	52.70%				
Length of stay	5.27	5.00	5.00	7.00	1.55
Speaking proficiency	4.94	4.00	5.00	6.00	1.36
Reading proficiency	4.94	4.00	6.00	6.00	1.43
Permanent visa	61.10%				

Notes: The Table reports summary statistics on all variables used. Numbers are computed for the full sample as well as the subsample of non-Japanese participants.

Table 13: Highest- and Lowest-Ranked Non-Japanese Applicants by Respondent Nationality

Respondent nationality	Highest-ranked applicant	Lowest-ranked applicant
Japan	Western-Japanese	Indonesia
China	Western-Japanese	Chinese
Taiwan	Western-Japanese	Vietnamese
South Korea	Western-Japanese	Vietnamese
Vietnam	Western-Japanese	South Korean

Notes: This Table complements the aggregate rankings shown in Figure 4 by reporting the highest- and lowest-ranked non-Japanese applicants within selected respondent-nationality groups. Nationality-specific rankings for smaller respondent groups should be interpreted descriptively due to limited sample sizes.

G Experimental Design Document and Participant Instructions

This appendix consolidates the design-document and participant-instruction material required by The Economic Journal’s replication policy for experimental papers (Instructions to Authors, §4.2). Where the manuscript’s other appendices (Appendix A–Appendix D) already cover the relevant material, those appendices are cross-referenced rather than duplicated.

G.1 Experimental design overview

Setting and target population. Perceived ethnic discrimination in the private rental housing market of the Greater Tokyo Metropolitan Area, among adult residents who are either Japanese citizens or foreign-born residents legally resident at the time of fieldwork.

Recruitment. The survey was administered through the *GMO Research* online panel via the *Qualtrics* platform. GMO Research was selected over Amazon Mechanical Turk (which has limited Japanese penetration) and operates a foreign-resident sub-panel suitable for the oversampled foreign-born quota. Detail: Appendix B.

Sampling frame and quotas. Quota sampling: target ≈ 800 native Japanese and ≈ 200 foreign-born respondents resident in Greater Tokyo. Foreign-born respondents were intentionally over-sampled relative to their population share ($\approx 5\%$ of Tokyo residents) to ensure sufficient statistical power for the EDS-interaction analyses (subsubsection 4.5.3) as well as the personal-group and group-group comparisons (subsection 4.4 and subsection 4.5). Realised sample summary statistics are reported in Table 12.

Eligibility. Respondents had to (i) be aged 18 or above; (ii) reside in Greater Tokyo at the time of the survey (validated by geolocation and a screening question); and (iii) not have participated in a related pilot. Foreign-born respondents were further required to self-identify as non-Japanese citizens.

Fieldwork window. Data collection took place in April–May 2025.

Informed consent. A written briefing was presented before participants entered the substantive questionnaire (text reproduced in subsection G.4 below). Participants gave informed consent by progressing past the briefing screen; withdrawal was permitted at any time without penalty.

G.2 Treatment design and randomisation

The experimental treatment varies the ethnic signal carried by the applicant’s name while holding all other applicant characteristics constant. The seven applicant profiles are documented in Table 1 and constructed using the procedure described in Appendix C. Each respondent evaluates the perceived viewing-invitation likelihood for each of the seven profiles in turn, evaluated against the same standardised property listing sourced from *LIFULL Homes*.

Within-subjects evaluation. The within-subjects design allows identification of relative ethnic-signal effects free of between-respondent compositional differences.

Personal-prospect question. After evaluating the chances of the seven applicants, respondents are asked to assess the probability that *they personally* would be invited to a viewing for the same property. This approach together with respondents’ stated own origin enables us to measure the personal-group and group-group discrimination discrepancy analyses (subsec-

tion 4.4, subsection 4.5).

Treatment-order randomisation. The order in which the seven applicant profiles were presented was randomised across respondents using Qualtrics’ randomisation logic, neutralising order-of-presentation effects. The per-respondent presentation order is recorded in the raw Qualtrics export and is reproducible from the deposited dataset.

Sample-size justification. The quota targets were set ex ante on the basis of (i) the GMO Research foreign-resident sub-panel reach estimate of 1,200–1,400 reachable foreign-born respondents; (ii) detectable-effect-size considerations for the planned subgroup analyses; and (iii) budget constraints under the CULS and Department of Land Economy funding award. No formal pre-registered power calculation was undertaken; the absence of formal pre-registration is acknowledged in the *Declarations* (Pre-registration disclosure) and in the cover letter.

G.3 Data quality procedures

See Appendix B for the full data-quality protocol (minimum completion-time thresholds, response-completeness and consistency checks, geolocation and device-metadata validation, duplicate-response prevention, pilot phase, multilingual default-language tracking).

G.4 Participant instructions: Japanese and English

This subsection provides the participant-facing instructions in Japanese (the language in which the survey was fielded by default) and the English translation used for instrument development.

Welcome and informed-consent briefing (QID1)

English (fielded version).

The purpose of this survey is to collect data for an undergraduate dissertation project at the Department of Land Economy, University of Cambridge. The survey should take approximately 5 minutes, and your responses will remain anonymous. The collected data will be used for academic research purposes only, and will not be used for any commercial purposes.

You can only take this survey once. You cannot go back to change your previous answers, so please answer the questions to the best of your ability. You can discontinue the survey at any point; however, participants will be compensated only upon completion of the survey. By checking the box below, you consent to our using the data for academic research. Thank you kindly for your time.

I have read the introductory information and give my consent to the use of this data for academic research. [*Response options: Yes / No.*]

Japanese (fielded version).

本調査の目的は、「都市部の居住分離に対する経済的および文化的影響: 住宅市場からの証拠」というプロジェクトのデータ収集です。調査には約5分かかり、回答は匿名のまま収集されます。データは学術研究目的にのみ使用され、最長5年後に削除されます。

本調査は1回のみ受けることができます。以前の回答を変更することはできませんので、できる限り正確に質問に回答してください。調査はいつでも中止することができますが、参加者への報酬は調査完了時にのみ支払われます。下の

ボックスにチェックを入れることで、学術研究のためにデータを使用することに同意したものとみなされます。ご協力ありがとうございます。

概要を読み、データを学術研究に使用することに同意します。[回答選択肢:はい/いいえ]

Section 1: socio-economic characteristics

The questionnaire transitions directly from the consent screen to the demographic block; there is no separate Section 1 instruction screen. Demographic items follow the wording of the Japanese Ministry of Justice *Basic Foreign Residents' Survey* and the *2020 National Census*. The first item is reproduced in both languages as an example.

Example item (QID2) — English.

What is your nationality of birth? [Response options: Japan; China; South Korea; Vietnam; Philippines; Brazil; Nepal; Indonesia; Taiwan; USA; Thailand; Other (please specify).]

Example item (QID2) — Japanese.

あなたの生まれた国はどこですか? [回答選択肢:日本/中国/韓国/ベトナム/フィリピン/ブラジル/ネパール/インドネシア/台湾/アメリカ/タイ/その他(具体的に記入ください)]

Section 2: viewing-likelihood evaluation

Each respondent evaluates seven applicants in random order (one per Qualtrics screen), all against the same standardised *LIFULL Homes* property listing (Figure 2). The two examples below show (a) the wording for the Japanese-baseline applicant (Taro Yamamoto, QID7) and (b) the personal-prospect (own) question (QID14) on which the personal-group discrimination discrepancy analysis in subsection 4.4 depends. The remaining six applicant items (QID8–QID13) follow the QID7 template with only the applicant name changed.

QID7 (Taro Yamamoto) — English.

Taro Yamamoto has just moved to Tokyo; he wants to rent the above property. He contacted the landlord and asked to view the property. What do you think is the chance of him being invited to a viewing? [Response on an 11-point scale, 0%–100% in 10-point increments.]

QID7 (Taro Yamamoto) — Japanese.

山本太郎さんは東京に引っ越してきたばかりで、上記の物件を借りたいと考えています。彼は家主に連絡して物件を内覧したいと申し出ました。彼が内覧に招待される可能性はどれくらいだと思いますか? [11段階尺度, 0%から100%まで10%刻みで回答]

QID14 (personal-prospect) — English.

If you want to rent the above property, and you have just contacted the landlord and asked to view the property, what do you think is the chance of you being invited to a viewing? [Response on the same 11-point scale.]

QID14 (personal-prospect) — Japanese.

あなたが上記の物件を借りたいと思って、家主に連絡して物件を内覧したいと頼んだとします。内覧に招待される可能性はどれくらいだと思いますか? [同じ11段階尺度で回答]

Section 3: Everyday Discrimination Scale (foreign-born respondents only)

Adapted from Williams et al. (1997). The intro and four items are reproduced verbatim below; the response scale is shared across the four items (*Almost every day / At least once a week / A few times a month / A few times a year / Less than once a year / Never*). The English wording is also reprinted in Appendix D.

QID33 intro — English.

In your day-to-day life, how often do any of the following things happen to you:

1. You are treated with less courtesy than other people.
2. You receive poorer services than other people at restaurants or stores.
3. People act as if they are afraid of you.
4. People act as if they think that you are dishonest.

QID33 intro — Japanese.

日常生活の中で、以下のような事柄がどのくらいの頻度で起こりますか?

1. 他の人よりも丁寧に扱われない。
2. レストランや店で他の人よりも質の悪いサービスを受ける。
3. 人々があなたを恐れているかのように行動する。
4. 人々があなたを不誠実だと思っているかのように行動する。

Declarations

Funding

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Ethics approval

This study was approved on 5 March 2025 by the Departmental Research Committee of the Department of Land Economy, University of Cambridge (reference DC05032025). All four co-authors are affiliated with the University of Cambridge, and a single Cambridge ethics approval covers the survey administered to native Japanese and foreign-born respondents in Greater Tokyo via the GMO Research panel in April–May 2025. Participants provided informed consent prior to participation.

Conflict of interest

The authors declare that they have no relevant financial or non-financial interests to disclose.

Author contributions

Jessica Alder: original research design, lead survey-instrument design, primary author of the empirical analyses and original dissertation work from which this paper was developed. **Sofie R. Waltl**: methodological lead, empirical analyses, supervisory input, manuscript revision, and overall framing. **Kate Konatsu Nishigai**: Japanese-language validation, legal expert, and translation oversight. **Helen X. H. Bao**: senior author and corresponding author; project supervision, survey-instrument design, manuscript revision, and submission.

Pre-registration disclosure

The study was not formally pre-registered with the AEA RCT Registry or an equivalent public registry. The empirical hypotheses tested in the paper were pre-specified in the analysis-script structure prior to the analysis, but no public pre-registration document exists.

Data availability statement

The data underlying this article were collected through an online survey administered via the GMO Research panel (Tokyo, Japan) and processed using Qualtrics. In accordance with *The Economic Journal*'s replication policy, the cleaned, de-identified individual-level dataset, the survey instrument (Japanese and English versions), and all analysis code (R) that reproduce the results in the manuscript and the appendix will be deposited in *The Economic Journal*'s replication repository upon acceptance of this manuscript (with a trusted alternative repository such as Zenodo as a fallback). De-identification entails removal of all GMO Research panel-member identifiers and panel-onboarding metadata; suppression of direct and indirect personally-identifying variables; and coarsening of small-cell demographic combinations where residual re-identification risk would otherwise be material. The complete archive is held by the corresponding author and may be shared on reasonable request pending the public deposit.